Aquifer Open Bible Dictionary

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I

Ibex

An ibex is a type of wild goat. The law of Moses declared it clean and allowed the Israelites to eat it (Deuteronomy 14:5).

See Goat.

Ibhar

A son born to David during his rule in Jerusalem (2 Samuel 5:15; 1 Chronicles 3:6; 14:5).

Ibis

The ibis (Threskiornis aethiopica) is a wading bird with a long, curved bill. This water bird is rare in the Holy Land today, but it might have lived there during Bible times. The ancient Egyptians considered the ibis sacred to their god Thoth (a god of wisdom and writing). The ibis has almost disappeared from Egypt now because the swamps along the Nile River have dried up.

Some Bible translations have identified the bird in Leviticus 11:17 as the ibis, which is classified as ceremonially unclean to eat. The same Hebrew word appears in Deuteronomy 14:16 and Isaiah 34:11, where most Bible translations use "great owl" instead of "ibis." Most Bible scholars today prefer the "great owl" translation.

See also Birds; Great Owl.

Ibleam

Ibleam was a city in the land of Manasseh (Joshua 17:11; Judges 1:27; 2 Kings 9:27). It may be the same as Bileam, a Levitical city west of the Jordan River between Samaria and Jezreel (1 Chronicles 6:70).

See Levitical Cities.

Ibneiah

Ibneiah was Jeroham's son from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 9:8).

Ibnijah

Ibnijah was the ancestor of Meshullam from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 9:8).

Ibri

Ibri was a Merarite Levite and Jaaziah's son, who lived during King David's time (1 Chronicles 24:27).

Ibsam

Ibsam was Tola's son from the tribe of Issachar (1 Chronicles 7:2).

Ibzan

Judge who ruled over Israel, or part of it, for seven years (Jgs 12:8–10). Ibzan was a native of Bethlehem, probably of Zebulun, and was buried in his place of birth. Jewish tradition identified Ibzan with Boaz and consequently understood his native city to be Bethlehem in Judah. Ibzan had 30 sons and 30 daughters and was a man of wealth and high social standing.

See also Judges, Book of.

Ichabod

Name given to Phinehas's son (Eli's grandson) to commemorate the glory that had departed from Israel, after the ark of God was taken by the Philistines (1 Sm 4:19–22; 14:3).

Phinehas was killed in the battle of Aphek, at the same time the Philistines had captured the ark. When Phinehas's wife heard of the tragedy, she went immediately into labor, and when the child was born, she named him Ichabod (meaning "no glory") to express her despair.

Iconium

A city in the southwest part of central Asia Minor. Its location was about 153 kilometers (95 miles) from the Mediterranean coast. Today, Iconium is the Turkish city of Konya, which is also the capital of the province of Konya.

Economy

Iconium was an agricultural center. It was famous for its wheat fields and apricot and plum orchards. It had an ideal location and climate. This helped establish Iconium as a major link in the trade routes between Syria, Ephesus, and Rome.

History

The origin of the city is uncertain. A group of immigrant tribes from northern Greece called the Phrygians founded it. The Greek historian Xenophon, who lived from around 428 to 354 BC, mentions Iconium. He says it was a Phrygian city visited by King Cyrus. Those from Iconium spoke the Phrygian language. So the inhabitants must have considered that they originated from there. The name of Iconium was first Phrygian.

Yet, a later myth added a Greek meaning to the name. According to this legend, a great flood destroys

humankind. Life is restored when Prometheus and Athena breathe life into human images. These images are made from mud left by subsiding waters. The Greek word for "image" is eikon. According to the legend, this is where Iconium gets its name.

In the third century BC, the Seleucid kings of Syria governed Iconium. They advocated for Greek culture. The Seleucids soon turned Iconium into a Hellenistic city where they spoke Greek. Each year, two appointed magistrates ruled the people. Later the Gauls and Pontic kings dominated Iconium from about 165 to 63 BC. Yet, it retained its Hellenistic character until New Testament times. In 36 BC, Mark Antony gave the city to King Antymas. When he died in 25 BC, Iconium joined the neighboring cities of Lystra, Derbe, and Pisidian Antioch. These cities became part of the province of Galatia. Then they incorporated into the Roman Empire.

Iconium in the Bible

The apostle Paul visited Iconium on his first missionary journey. After he left Pisidian Antioch (Acts 13:51), Paul came to the synagogue in Iconium. At first, his preaching won the approval of both the Jews and Greeks. But "unbelieving Jews" soon incited a riot against him (14:1–7). Paul fled to Lystra, but the Iconian Jews followed him. They stoned him and left him for dead (verse 19; compare 2 Timothy 3:11). Cared for by friends, Paul joined Barnabas in Derbe. There they made many disciples. Then later they returned to Iconium to strengthen the Christians there (Acts 14:20–23). Later Paul went on a second missionary journey. The Christians at Iconium commended Timothy to Paul and Silas (16:1–2).

Idalah

Idalah was a town assigned to the tribe of Zebulun for an inheritance (Joshua 19:15). Scholars have generally identified it with modern Khirbet el-Hawarah, northwest of Nazareth.

Idbash

Idbash was one of the descendants of Etam from the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 4:3).

Iddo

1. Father of Ahinadab, Solomon's official at Mahanaim, who provisioned the royal household (1 Kgs 4:14).
2. Gershonite Levite, descendant of Joah and forefather of Zerah (1 Chr 6:21); perhaps alternately called Adaiah in verse 41. See Adaiah #2.
3. Zechariah's son and the chief officer of Manasseh's half-tribe in Gilead during David's reign (1 Chr 27:21).
4. Prophet and seer who recorded the events of Solomon's reign concerning Jeroboam, Nebat's son in a book of visions (2 Chr 9:29), Rehoboam's acts in his genealogical records (12:15), and Abijah's life as part of a commentary (13:22).
5. Grandfather of Zechariah the prophet (Zec 1:1, 7). Iddo was a well-known priest who returned to Jerusalem from exile in 538 BC, and whose household was headed by Zechariah during Joiakim's reign as high priest during the postexilic era (Neh 12:16). According to Ezra 5:1 and 6:14, Zechariah, and not Berechiah his father, was considered Iddo's successor. See Zechariah (Person) #20.
6. Leading Levite at Casiphia in Babylonia to whom Ezra sent a delegation of men requesting priests and temple servants to join Ezra's caravan returning to Palestine for service in the Jerusalem temple (Ezr 8:17).

Idols, Idolatry

An idol is a human-made image or an image of something in the natural world that people worship as a god. It can also be anything that receives worship that belongs only to the one true God. Idolatry is the worship of an idol.

Some people served idols in very literal ways. In ancient Egypt, people regularly dressed statues of gods and gave them food as part of religious ceremonies.

The Bible gives an example of the worship of the false god Baal in the contest on Mount Carmel. The priests of Baal shouted loudly, moved around the altar, and cut themselves with "knives and lances" (1 Kings 18:26–29). Baal worship became common among the people of Israel during the time of the kings.

Idols and Idolatry in the Old Testament

Abraham's ancestors worshiped idols in Mesopotamia (Joshua 24:2). Archaeologists have found many images of gods in that region. Ancient Mesopotamian religious writings also show that people worshiped many gods. This belief in many gods is called polytheism.

The Israelites also struggled with idolatry. Part of this may have come from a common human desire to worship a god that people can see and experience through their physical senses.

The Israelites adopted many forms of idol worship from the peoples around them. The descendants of Jacob lived in Egypt for more than 400 years. During

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this time, they were exposed to the worship of many gods. This influenced their religious beliefs and practices.

At Mount Sinai, Moses was receiving the Ten Commandments from the Lord. Meanwhile, the people asked Aaron to make gods for them (Exodus 32:1–6). Aaron made a golden calf. This image was similar to Egyptian forms of worship. The Egyptians worshiped several gods represented by cattle, including the Apis bull, the goddess Hathor, who was often shown as a cow, and the Mnevis calf.

After Jeroboam spent time in Egypt (1 Kings 11:40), he became king of Israel. He later set up two golden calves, one at Bethel and one at Dan (12:26–33). Because of this, the Bible describes Jeroboam as the king who caused Israel to sin (2 Kings 3:3).

Household Gods in Israel

In the time of the patriarchs, the Bible mentions teraphim, or household gods. Archaeologists have found examples of these idols at Ur of the Chaldeans, Nuzi, and other ancient sites. Ancient cuneiform tablets, which were written on clay, also mention them. The teraphim that Rachel stole from Laban were small enough to hide in a camel's saddlebag (Genesis 31:34).

However, by the time of David, some of these idols seem to have been larger. When Saul's men came to kill David, Michal, David's wife and daughter of Saul, helped David escape. She then placed a household idol in the bed so that the men would think David was sick (1 Samuel 19:11–16).

God's Commands Against Idolatry

The second commandment clearly forbids idolatry (Exodus 20:4–5):

"You shall not make for yourself an idol in the form of anything in the heavens above, on the earth below, or in the waters beneath. You shall not bow down to them or worship them; for I, the LORD your God, am a jealous God" (see also Exodus 34:17; Leviticus 19:4; 26:1; Deuteronomy 4:15–19; 27:1–5).

This commandment supports the first commandment. It protects the truth that God is unique and that his glory belongs to him alone.

In the time of Samuel, the idea of idolatry was also applied more broadly. Samuel told King Saul that "arrogance is like the wickedness of idolatry" (1 Samuel 15:23).

Before Israel entered Canaan, the Lord repeatedly warned the Israelites not to marry people from the nations living there. God had commanded Israel to remove those nations from the land. One purpose of this command was to keep Israel from being led away from faithful obedience to God (Exodus 34:16; Deuteronomy 7:3–4).

The New Testament also teaches that close relationships can influence a person's faith and conduct (see 1 Corinthians 15:33; 2 Corinthians 6:14).

Israel's history shows the danger behind this warning. Marriages with people who worshiped other gods often led the Israelites away from the Lord. One of the clearest examples is Solomon (1 Kings 11:1–8). When Solomon grew old, his wives turned his heart toward other gods, and he was no longer fully faithful to the Lord his God (verse 4).

Idolatry in the Time of the Judges

During the time of the judges, the Bible describes a well-known case of idol worship (Judges 17:1–18:31). The mother of a man from Ephraim named Micah gave 200 pieces of silver to a silversmith. He used the silver to make an idol for her son.

Micah also had a shrine, an ephod, which was a special religious garment or object, and teraphim, or household gods. He hired a traveling Levite to serve as his priest.

Later, men from the tribe of Dan took the Levite, the idol, and the other objects used for worship. They brought them to Dan, set up the idol there, and worshiped it (Judges 18:30–31).

Idolatry and Israel's Kings

In the Bible, the kings of Israel are often judged by how they dealt with the "high places," which were places of worship, and with idols.

King Asa removed the idols his ancestors had made (1 Kings 15:12). He also removed Maacah from her position as queen mother because she had made an offensive image for the goddess Asherah. Asa cut down the image and burned it (verse 13). King Ahab, however, worshiped idols and led Israel further into idolatry (21:26; compare 16:30–33).

King Hezekiah "removed the high places, shattered the sacred pillars, and cut down the Asherah poles" (2 Kings 18:4; 2 Chronicles 31:1). He also ended the worship of a bronze serpent. This example shows how an object that once had a good purpose can later become an idol. Moses had lifted up this bronze serpent on a pole so that Israelites who had been bitten by snakes could live (Numbers 21:9; see also John 3:14).

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The bronze serpent was kept until the time of Hezekiah. People called it Nehushtan, honored it as sacred, and burned incense to it. Hezekiah destroyed it because the people had begun to worship an object that had originally been used for good (2 Kings 18:4).

How People Made Idols

The prophet Isaiah described how people made idols in human form (Isaiah 40:19–20; 44:9–17). They cast images in molds using melted metal (40:19; 44:10). Blacksmiths forged statues from metal (44:12). Carpenters carved them from wood (44:13–17). Workers then covered them with precious metal (40:19).

People also made small clay images and plaques by shaping the clay and heating it in a kiln. Other statues were carved from stone.

Idols in the Psalms and the Exile

The book of Psalms also speaks against idols and images (Psalms 96:5; 97:7; 106:34–39). Psalms 115:4–8 and 135:15–18 describe idols as powerless and unable to help those who worship them.

The northern and southern kingdoms of Israel were taken into exile because the people turned away from God and worshiped idols. The Jewish people understood that idolatry had contributed to their exile. During their time in Babylon, they developed a strong rejection of idol worship. This rejection of idolatry continued to be an important part of Judaism.

Idols and Idolatry in the New Testament

The New Testament gives its fullest discussion of idolatry in Paul's First Letter to the Corinthians. The Greek word for idolatry is eidololatreia, and the word for an idol worshiper is eidololatres.

In an earlier letter that has not survived, Paul told the Corinthians not to associate with people who claimed to be believers but still worshiped idols (1 Corinthians 5:9–11).

After receiving that letter, the Corinthians may have asked Paul for more explanation. In 1 Corinthians, Paul then speaks again about "idolaters" in 5:10–11, 6:9, 10:7, and "idolatry" in 10:14.

The words "idolatry" and "idolater" are related to two other Greek terms. The first is eidolon, meaning "idol" (1 Corinthians 8:4; 10:19; 12:2). The second is eidolothutos, meaning "food sacrificed to idols" (1 Corinthians 8:1, 4, 7; 10:19).

Food Sacrificed to Idols

Paul strongly condemns Christians who take part in sacrifices to idols and then eat the food offered in those sacrifices. He calls such people idol worshipers because taking part in these sacrifices meant sharing in fellowship with demons.

Paul therefore forbids Christians to eat sacrificial food in pagan temples where idols were worshiped. In this way, his view was similar to that of many Jews of his time. They connected pagan gods with idols. Paul also contrasts idols with "the living and true God" (1 Thessalonians 1:9).

At the same time, Paul says that an idol has no real power in itself (1 Corinthians 8:4). However, he also teaches that demons are connected with sacrifices offered to idols (10:20).

Paul did not allow Christians to take part in meals connected with idol worship in pagan temples. He taught that those who joined these meals were sharing in fellowship with demons (see 1 Corinthians 10:19–21).

However, Paul allowed Christians to buy and eat food that had first been offered to idols and was later sold in the marketplace. If they ate this food at home, they were not taking part in idol worship.

They could eat it with a clear conscience unless doing so would harm the faith of another believer. In that case, they should choose not to eat it for the sake of the weaker believer. Paul treated this as a matter of conscience (1 Corinthians 10:25–29). But taking part in pagan festivals and eating meals offered to idols as part of worship was not permitted.

Meals at Corinth

Before becoming Christians, the Corinthians regularly took part in meals connected with pagan worship. Some of them seem to have continued this practice after becoming Christians.

In Corinth, these meals were common at public festivals and private celebrations. People believed that these gods were present because sacrifices had been offered to them. Paul understood these "gods" as "demons." Therefore, he taught that taking part in these meals joined a person with demons and made that person an idol worshiper.

Paul also pointed to the history of Israel as a warning. On several occasions, the Israelites were drawn into idolatry by joining the religious celebrations of neighboring peoples (for example, Numbers 25; compare Exodus 32:6). These celebrations also involved sexual immorality.

In 1 Corinthians 10, Paul uses Israel's unfaithfulness as a negative example. By taking part in pagan celebrations, the Israelites were led into idolatry and sexual

Idumea, Idumeans

immorality. This brought God's judgment and destruction on them.

Idolatry in Paul's Other Letters

In Paul's other letters, he mentions idolatry but does not explain it as fully as he does in 1 Corinthians. Paul speaks against both direct idol worship and what may be called figurative idolatry. Figurative idolatry means desiring or valuing something more than God.

In Romans 1:18–32, Paul connects sexual immorality and other sins with idolatry. He says that the Gentiles should have recognized God through what he created. Instead, they turned away from the immortal and invisible God and worshiped mortal, visible images. Because they rejected God, Paul says that God gave them over to follow the sinful desires of their hearts (Romans 1:24).

Paul also includes idolatry among the "acts of the flesh," meaning sinful actions that come from human desires opposed to God (see Galatians 5:19–20). He also says that idol worshipers are among those who will not inherit the kingdom of God (see 1 Corinthians 6:9).

In Ephesians 5:5, Paul again says that idol worshipers will not inherit the kingdom of Christ and of God. In this passage, however, idolatry includes more than worshiping idols in pagan temples. Paul also connects idolatry with greed.

The verse describes a greedy person as an idol worshiper. The idea seems to be that a greedy person gives their desires the place that belongs to God. In this sense, greed becomes a form of idolatry.

Colossians 3:5 makes this connection even more directly by saying that greed is idolatry.

See also Canaanite Gods and Religion; Gods and Goddesses; Grove; High Place.

Idumea, Idumeans

Idumea was the Greek name for the region south of Judah where many Edomites settled after Edom became weaker. The Idumeans were their descendants, and the Bible connects their family line with Esau.

What Does the Name Idumea Mean?

The term Idumea comes from the Greek form of Edom, which means "red." The change from Edomite to Idumean resulted from the conquests of Alexander the Great, which made Greek the common language of the area.

Where Was Idumea Located?

The name Idumea referred to the former land of the Edomites. It also referred to part of southern Judah. The descendants of Esau lived there after the Jews were taken to Babylon. This happened after Nebuchadnezzar conquered Judah in 586 BC.

During the intertestamental period, the time between the Old Testament and the New Testament, Idumea's northern border was at Beth-zur. Beth-zur was a few miles north of Hebron. Idumea also included part of the Shephelah, the low hill country of Judah, extending down into the former Philistine country (1 Maccabees 4:15, 22, 61; 5:65).

Where Did the Idumeans Come From?

The Idumeans were first known as Edomites. Later, they were known as Nabateans, and finally as Idumeans. Their ancestors came from the family line of Esau, Jacob's older brother. Jacob cheated Esau out of both his birthright, the special rights of the firstborn son, and his blessing from his father (Genesis 27:1–45). This led to conflict between the Israelites and Esau's descendants throughout the biblical period.

Because of this long conflict, the Edomites were glad when the Babylonians conquered Israel. After 586 BC, the Babylonians took control of the kingdom. Then the Edomites moved into the land that the Israelites had left.

How Did Idumea Change over Time?

About 300 BC, Arabian tribes invaded Edom and took Petra, the Edomite capital. This forced the Edomites who remained to move into the area south of Judah. This area later became part of Idumea.

The people who attacked Edom were called Nabateans. They made Sela, also called Petra, the center of their caravan trade. Caravan trade was the transport and sale of goods by groups of travelers. Their trade routes went from east to west and from north to south.

The Nabateans were desert traders. Greek ideas also influenced them. At Petra, they shaped the bowl-like valley into a great city. They cut temples, tombs, and other buildings into the colorful red sandstone.

The Nabateans also became skilled traders and farmers. Josephus, a Jewish historian, said they were not known for war. Instead, they were skilled in trade, art, and farming.

The Nabateans also built Avedat, a strong desert city in an important location. Together, Avedat and Petra gave them control of the caravan routes. The

Nabateans were powerful from about 100 BC to AD 100. After that, the Romans slowly weakened them. The Romans changed the trade routes from south of the Dead Sea to the area around Damascus and Palmyra.

What Happened to Idumea under Jewish and Roman Rule?

During the intertestamental period the Jews who returned to their land had small battles along the border with the Idumeans. Judas Maccabeus captured Hebron (1 Maccabees 5:65). John Hyrcanus forced the Idumeans to become Jews and be circumcised. Antipater, the governor of Idumea, was an Idumean. Julius Caesar made him procurator, or Roman governor, of Judea. Antipater appointed his son Herod as governor of Galilee. This helped Herod later become king of Judea. He became known as Herod the Great.

After the Romans conquered Judea in AD 70 and again in AD 135, Idumea disappeared from history. In recent years, archaeologists have begun to uncover some of the history of the Idumeans and the Nabateans, the people who conquered them.

See also Edom, Edomites; Judaism.

Iezer, Iezerites

Iezer and Iezerites are shortened forms of the names Abiezer and Abiezrite. Abiezer was a son of Gilead, and the Abiezrites were Abiezer's descendants (Numbers 26:30).

See Abiezer #1.

Igal

1. A son of Joseph from the tribe of Issachar. He was one of the 12 spies sent by Moses to search out Canaan (Numbers 13:7).
2. A son of Nathan and one of the mighty men of King David (2 Samuel 23:36). In 1 Chronicles 11:38 he is called Joel, the brother of Nathan. In Hebrew, this names is only one letter different from Igal.
3. A son of Shemaiah and a descendant of King David through King Jehoiachin (1 Chronicles 3:22).

Igdaliah

Igdaliah was the father of Hanan. The sons of Hanan had a room next to the temple during the reign of King Jehoiakim (Jeremiah 35:4).

Igeal

Igeal is the King James Version spelling of Igal, Shemaiah's son, in 1 Chronicles 3:22.

See Igal #3.

Ignatius and His Epistles

Ignatius was bishop of Antioch in Syria in the late first century. His writings were very close to the thoughts of the New Testament writers. He wrote seven letters while being taken to Rome as a prisoner. He was going there to die for his faith (probably AD 107).

He wrote letters to churches in cities through which he passed, Philadelphia and Smyrna. He wrote letters to churches that sent representatives to visit him during this final journey—namely, Ephesus, Tralles, and Magnesia. He sent a letter to the church in Rome before he arrived. He asked them not to try to stop the Roman leaders from killing him for his faith. He also wrote a letter to Polycarp, the bishop of Smyrna.

These letters are similar to the New Testament letters. They reveal a strong commitment to Christ and to the physical facts of his birth, death, and resurrection. The letters of Ignatius parallel the Gospels in several places and appropriate language from a number of the Pauline letters.

The letters of Ignatius are evidence of the rapid development of the episcopal structure in the early church of Asia Minor and Syria. In the New Testament, the local church was governed by a body of equal officers called elders or bishops. In these letters, there is a reference to a single ruling bishop in each city except Rome. Ignatius is the first writer to use the term "catholic" (meaning "universal") to describe the church. His use of the term showed that churches were connected. They believed the same things about Jesus and worked together. When one church had problems or ideas, they would send people to talk with other churches.

Ignatius opposed the Ebionite heresy. This heresy demanded the keeping of the Jewish regulations as the way of salvation. According to Ignatius, to affirm Christ the believer must reject Jewish practices. The Christian must worship on the Lord's Day, the day of his resurrection, rather than observe the Jewish sabbaths. Yet he did view the church as the continuation of the Old Testament people of God and the prophets as disciples who looked forward to Christ.

Ignatius also attacked Docetism. This view held that Christ only appeared to have a real birth, death, and resurrection. In reciting the facts of Christ's life, Ignatius was the first one outside the New Testament writers to speak of the virgin birth of Jesus. Ignatius also emphasized the fact that the apostles touched the body of their risen Lord. Ignatius said it was the

real suffering of Jesus Christ on the cross and his physical resurrection that made it possible for him to face martyrdom.

Iim

1. The King James Version spelling of Iyim. Iim is a shortened form of Iye-abarim. (Numbers 33:45).

See Iye-abarim, Iyim.

1. A town located near Edom. It was in the southern part of the land that was assigned to the tribe of Judah (Joshua 15:29).

Ije-abarim

The King James Version spelling of Iye-abarim. This was one of the places Israel stopped at during their journey through the wilderness (Numbers 21:11 and 33:44).

See Iye-abarim, Iyim.

Ijon

Town assigned to Naphtali's tribe in the extreme north of Palestine. Some identify it with Tell ed-Dibbon between the Litani River and Mt Hermon, but this is disputed. Ijon was one of the towns taken by Ben-hadad of Damascus during Baasha's reign (c. 900 BC; 1 Kgs 15:20; 2 Chr 16:4). Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria captured the town and deported its people during Pekah's reign (c. 733 BC; 2 Kgs 15:29).

Ikkesh

A man from Tekoa whose son Ira was one of the mighty men of King David (2 Samuel 23:26; 1 Chronicles 11:28). He was head of a division of 24,000 men during the sixth month of the year (1 Chronicles 27:9).

Ilai

Ilai is another name for Zalmon, a famous warrior, in 1 Chronicles 11:29.

See Zalmon (Person).

Illness

Illness is a condition of poor health or disease that affects the body or mind. The Bible describes many kinds of illness and records that God sometimes brought healing through prophets, Jesus, and the apostles.

See Disease; Heal, Healing; Medicine and Medical Practice.

Illyricum

Illyricum was a Roman province northwest of Macedonia. The height of the Roman Empire was around AD 117. This was when it included Dalmatia. The border of Illyricum was the Adriatic Sea on the west. The provinces of Pannonia bordered it on the north, Upper Moesia on the east, and Macedonia on the south. Today Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia, and Yugoslavia occupy that territory.

Throughout the fourth century BC, the people of Illyricum warred with the Macedonians. Then the Macedonian ruler Philip II defeated them in 359 BC. During the third century BC, their acts of piracy against Greek and Roman ships led to a war with Rome. This war continued on and off for 60 years (229–168 BC). There was a series of revolts and occasional Roman rule. Then Illyricum became part of the empire in 11 BC. The Romans renamed it Dalmatia. It took another 20 years for the complete integration of the people into Roman culture.

In 229 BC, the Roman historian Polybius stated that "the Illyrians were not the enemies of this people or that, but were the common enemies of all." Later, Strabo, a first-century Greek geographer, said similar things. He described the people of Illyricum as savage and greedy.

The only New Testament reference to Illyricum is in the statement of the apostle Paul. He said he preached the gospel from Jerusalem as far as Illyricum (Romans 15:19). Acts does not document a ministry in that region. Yet, Paul may have visited Illyricum during his visit to Macedonia and Achaia. This was before returning to Jerusalem (Acts 20:1–2).

Paul expressed a desire to continue his ministry in Spain (Romans 15:28). Spain had a fully Latin culture. In Illyricum, he would have had his first experience in a culture that was more Latin than Greek.

See also Dalmatia.

Image of God

The phrase "image of God" means that human beings reflect God's nature in special ways. This is the most important thing we can say about what it means to be human from a Christian viewpoint. Among all created things, only humans are like God in ways that allow them to have a close relationship with God.

The Original Creation

God decided to create men and women to be like himself. The Bible tells us this in Genesis 1:26–27, where God uses two words to describe how humans would

Image of God

be like him: "image" and "likeness." These two words mean almost the same thing. God also gave humans authority to take care of the animals.

Genesis 2:7 clearly states that God made the first human become a living being. This passage does not describe humans developing from previously living creatures. It also does not suggest that the image of God evolved from a lower form of life. From the moment God created the first man and woman, they reflected God's image. Both men and women equally share this special likeness to God (Genesis 1:27).

Other passages that talk about people being created in the image of God are found in:

- Genesis 5:1
- Genesis 9:6
- 1 Corinthians 11:7
- James 3:9

Ephesians 4:24 and Colossians 3:10 refer to humanity's redemptive re-creation (through Jesus, humanity is restored or renewed in a way that reflects God's original intention for creation). The passages are also important for understanding humanity's original likeness to God. Even though the Bible does not mention this idea often, it is very important. It affects everything about how God and humans relate to each other.

What Makes Humans Special?

Only humans are made in God's image (Genesis 1). Animals, fish, and birds do not have this special quality. Some theologians think that angels are also made in God's image because angels are morally good, but the Bible does not tell us this directly.

Humans are made from the dust of the ground, so we share some things with the earth and other living creatures. Our bodies work in ways similar to animals. But humans are unique in every way. The whole person (not just one part) is made in God's image. The biblical concept is not that the image is in man and woman, but that man and woman are the image of God.

How Do Humans Reflect the Image of God?

Humanity's connection with the earth is most clearly visible in the human body. So, we can best see how humans reflect God's image in our spiritual nature. We can think, make choices, and take responsibility for our actions. These abilities make us different from animals and show how we are like God. While animals exist because God made them, humans have a special relationship with God. The animals have their existence from God, but humans have their being in God. Humans are referred to as God's "offspring" in Acts 17:28–29.

Ephesians 4:24 and Colossians 3:10 show us another important part of being made in God's image. These verses explain how God makes believers new by restoring his image in them. This happens by giving them:

- righteousness (doing what is right),
- holiness (being set apart for God), and
- true knowledge of God.

In other words, Paul says that when God redeems people, God re-creates them to be like Jesus. Jesus shows God's image perfectly without any sin. When humans first sinned, sin damaged the image of God in humans. But, through salvation, God works to restore this image. While Ephesians and Colossians tell us about this renewal in God's image, other parts of the Bible explain more about how Jesus helps make this possible.

Jesus and the Image of God

Jesus Christ is the perfect image of God (2 Corinthians 4:4; Colossians 1:15; Hebrews 1:3). This is often understood as a reference to the divinity of Jesus (being like God). When we see Jesus, we see what God the Father is like (John 14:9). However, in these passages, Jesus is shown as both God and human (this is called the incarnation, which means God taking human form). As the perfect human, Jesus completely shows us what God wanted all humans to be like, starting with the first human, Adam. This is why Jesus is called the "last Adam." He perfectly fulfilled God's original plan for humanity.

As the last Adam and the Mediator of the new covenant, Jesus helps his followers become more like him (Romans 8:29). Even though he was perfect, he became like us in every way except sin. He did this so he could remove our sin and help us reflect his own glory. The Holy Spirit works in believers to make them more and more like Jesus (2 Corinthians 3:18). The believer is to "clothe [themselves] with the Lord Jesus Christ" (Romans 13:14; Galatians 3:27; compare Ephesians 4:24; Colossians 3:10, "the new self" in the image of God). This action is also described as Christ "formed" in the believer in Galatians 4:19.

This process of becoming like Jesus (called sanctification) continues throughout a believer's life. It will only be fully complete when Jesus returns and raises believers from the dead. At that time, even our physical bodies will be changed to be like the glorious body of Jesus (Philippians 3:21). This final transformation will make us even more wonderful than when God first created humans in his image. As the Bible says, we

will exchange our earthly image for a heavenly one (1 Corinthians 15:49).

See also Man; Woman.

Imalkue

An Arab chieftain who was in charge of Antiochus, the son of Alexander. Trypho, who had once supported Alexander, sought the aid of Imalkue to have Antiochus crowned king instead of Demetrius. Trypho succeeded and Antiochus became King Antiochus VI. Demetrius's troops supported the new king and routed Demetrius (1 Macc 11:39–55).

Imlah

The father of Michaiah, a prophet during King Ahab's reign. The king hated Michaiah for speaking the truth (1 Kings 22:8–9; 2 Chronicles 18:7–8).

Immanuel

Immanuel is a Hebrew masculine name meaning "God with us." The name appears twice in the Old Testament (Isaiah 7:14; 8:8) and once in the New Testament (Matthew 1:23). It is sometimes transliterated "Emmanuel."

In the Old Testament, Immanuel was the name of a child born during King Ahaz's time. God gave this child as a sign to Ahaz that God would save Judah from attacks by Israel and Syria. The name symbolized that God would show his presence with his people through this salvation. The greater application is that this is a prophecy of the birth of the incarnate God, Jesus the Messiah, as shown in Matthew.

The Prophecy During Isaiah's Time

While focusing on the birth of Jesus as Immanuel, people have sometimes overlooked the historical events during King Ahaz's time. Ahaz was the son of a good king, Jotham, and the grandson of another godly ruler, Uzziah. But during his reign, Ahaz turned away from the Lord and worshiped idols.

He "made cast images of the Baals" (2 Chronicles 28:2). He "burned incense in the Valley of Ben-hinnom," and even "sacrificed his sons in the fire" (verses 3–4). Because of this, the Lord allowed Rezin, king of Syria, and Pekah, king of Israel, to defeat Ahaz. The Edomites also invaded Judah. The Philistines attacked the Shephelah and the Negev, capturing several cities (verses 17–18).

Ahaz asked Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria (745–727 BC) for help against Israel and Syria. Tiglath-pileser accepted tribute from Ahaz but attacked him anyway (2 Chronicles 28:20–21). When Ahaz went to Damascus to meet the Assyrian king, he saw an altar and made offerings to the gods of Syria there (verse 23). He had a copy of this altar made and placed it in the temple of Jerusalem (2 Kings 16:10–12).

God told the prophet Isaiah to confront Ahaz at the end of the channel of the upper pool. God's message to the king was to "stand firm in your faith," because the attacking kings would fall (Isaiah 7:7–9). Isaiah told Ahaz to ask the Lord for a sign, but the king refused. He gave an answer that sounded respectful toward God (verse 12).

After Ahaz refused, the Lord gave him a sign: a young woman would conceive and bear a son and call his name Immanuel (Isaiah 7:14). By the time the child was old enough to eat curds and honey, the two kings who threatened Judah would already be gone. In context, curds and honey likely reflect the hardship and disruption that would come upon the land. Then the king of Assyria would destroy their lands. The people would become captives, leaving the land empty and uncultivated. A man would have a cow for milk to make curds, and wild honey would be collected from the overgrown brush in the neglected land.

The identity of the woman and child in Isaiah's time is uncertain. Some suggest the woman was Abijah, the wife of King Ahaz, and their son, Hezekiah, was Immanuel. However, this has not been proven, and it seems unlikely that a man like Ahaz would be Immanuel's father.

Some suggest that Isaiah's wife was Immanuel's mother. Isaiah 7:14 prophesies Immanuel's birth. Isaiah 8:3 describes the conception and birth of Isaiah's son, Maher-shalal-hash-baz. His name means "swift to plunder and quick to spoil." This name pointed to the coming defeat of Judah's enemies.

Before the child could talk, the king of Assyria would conquer Syria and Israel (Isaiah 8:4). Isaiah said he and his children were "signs and symbols in Israel from the LORD" (verse 18). This supports the view that Isaiah's son was also called Immanuel.

The Lord sent a message to Immanuel (Isaiah 8:5–10). Since the people rejected the Lord's kind invitation, the Assyrians would invade and occupy Immanuel's land. The people's schemes would fail because "God is with us" ('immanu'el). This phrase uses Immanuel's name to show the Lord's presence.

The Prophecy Fulfilled in Jesus

More than 700 years after King Ahaz, God sent his Son. All uncertainty about the identity of Immanuel disappeared. His mother was a virgin from Nazareth named

Mary (Miriam), engaged to a man named Joseph. Matthew 1:23 cites Isaiah 7:14 as fulfilled in the birth of Jesus. The Scripture is clear that Joseph and Mary had not been together as husband and wife before Jesus was born (Matthew 1:25).

The Gospel of Luke emphasizes the same detail. When Mary learned of the child's conception, she questioned the angel. "'How can this be,' Mary asked the angel, 'since I am a virgin?'" (Luke 1:34). The angel explained, "The Holy Spirit will come upon you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. So the Holy One to be born will be called the Son of God" (verse 35). John's Gospel confirms this: Jesus is "the one and only Son, who is Himself God" (John 1:18). In other words, the child would be unique, being both God and human.

There were important differences between the Immanuel of Isaiah's time and Mary's son Immanuel:

1. The first was a type (an early symbol or preview). The second was the antitype (the true fulfillment). The first was the shadow. The second was the reality.
2. The first symbolized freedom from foreign control. The second was the savior from human oppression.
3. The first showed God's presence for a few years. The second Immanuel is the son who lives forever.

Jesus often emphasized the idea of "God with us." He told his disciples that he would be present when two or three gathered in his name (Matthew 18:20). Before Jesus ascended to heaven, he assured his disciples he would stay with them "always, even to the end of the age" (28:20).

Jesus also spoke about the promise of the Holy Spirit, who "abides with you and will be in you" (John 14:17). The Holy Spirit will stay with them forever (verse 16). Paul speaks of "Christ in you, the hope of glory" (Colossians 1:27), showing that God dwells inside every believer. At the end of time, as revealed to the apostle John, the Lord said: "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man, and He will dwell with them. They will be His people, and God Himself will be with them as their God" (Revelation 21:3).

See also Messiah; Names of God.

Immer (Person)

Priest in the time of David. He became the ancestral head of a house of priests: Pashhur, the priest who had Jeremiah arrested and placed in stocks, was a descendant of Immer (Jer 20:1). There were 1,052 priests of the subclan of Immer who returned from the exile (1 Chr 9:12; Ezr 2:37; Neh 7:40). A descendant of Immer helped rebuild the Jerusalem wall (Neh 3:29) and 128 priests under Amashsai (also a descendant) helped resettle the city and tend the temple (Neh 11:13–14).

Immer (Place)

Immer was a place in Babylon. Some Jews who returned from there could not find records of their family history. As a result, they could not prove that they belonged to the people of Israel (Ezra 2:59; Nehemiah 7:61).

Immersion

Immersion is a method of baptism whereby the person baptizing dips the person being baptized all the way under water.

See Baptism.

Imna

Imna was Helem's son from the tribe of Asher (1 Chronicles 7:35).

Imnah

1. Asher's son (Gn 46:17; 1 Chr 7:30) and founder of the Imnite family (Nm 26:44).
2. Levite and Kore's father. Kore was a temple assistant during King Hezekiah's reign (2 Chr 31:14).

Imnite

Any descendant of Imnah from the tribe of Asher (Numbers 26:44).

See Imnah #1.

Impalement

The insertion of a pointed stake into a human body. It was likely practiced in ancient Egypt, Assyria, Babylonia, Persia, and possibly also in Israel. There are, however, many problems in understanding what impalement means in the Old Testament. Its meaning varies in different passages.

Greek documents can be unclear. They use the same word for both impalement and crucifixion. (In crucifixion, they fasten the body to a stake rather than puncturing it.) It is also not clear whether the impalement is done to a living body or to a corpse. Probably, both types of impalement were used. The former was for execution. The latter was to expose the corpse to the elements, beasts, and disgrace. Furthermore, it is not clear to what extent hanging in the Old Testament refers to impalement. Its typical use with on (not from) may suggest a desire for some form of impalement.

Mesopotamian sources shed some light on impalement. It was a method of execution. One case was for a woman who caused her husband's death (Code of Hammurabi 153). Another was for a woman who aborted herself (Middle Assyrian Laws 53). The latter law states that the woman should be impaled, regardless of whether she survived the abortion. Assyrian kings claimed to have hung war captives on stakes. Assyrian art shows impaled bodies in battle scenes. The stake could be pushed up into the chest, with the body facedown, or between the legs, with the body upright.

Darius's decree in Ezra 6:11 to rebuild the Jerusalem temple allowed for punishing violators, possibly by impalement. If the expression hang on a tree [stake] (for instance, Genesis 40:19; Deuteronomy 21:22; Joshua 8:29; 10:26; Esther 2:23) refers to impalement, a corpse was being impaled (Joshua 10:26). This interpretation also applies to Deuteronomy 21:22. There, the victim is first killed and then "hung." The similarity to Christ's crucifixion (Galatians 3:13) is the disgrace, not the method. Other possible examples of impalement are found in 2 Samuel 4:12 and 21:6–13.

See also Criminal Law and Punishment.

Imprecatory Psalms

The psalms that contain curses or wishes for bad things for their enemies. These elements appear in 18 psalms:

- Psalm 5
- Psalm 17
- Psalm 28
- Psalm 35
- Psalm 40
- Psalm 55
- Psalm 59
- Psalm 70
- Psalm 71
- Psalm 74
- Psalm 79
- Psalm 80
- Psalm 94
- Psalm 109
- Psalm 129
- Psalm 137
- Psalm 139
- Psalm 140

These elements are usually expressed as a prayer or wish for judgment to happen to their enemies.

To the casual reader, such wishes might seem to contradict the rest of Scripture, especially with the teaching of Jesus. Leviticus 19:17–18 says, "You must not harbor hatred against your brother in your heart. Directly rebuke your neighbor, so that you will not incur guilt on account of him. Do not seek revenge or bear a grudge against any of your people, but love your neighbor as yourself."

Jesus argues that neighbor includes everyone (Luke 10:29–37). In the Sermon on the Mount, Jesus said, "Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you" (Matthew 5:44; compare with verses 38–48). This idea agrees with the Old Testament, which teaches us to help our enemies (Proverbs 25:21–22; compare Romans 12:20).

Psalm 109 appears to contradict the teachings of Jesus because it has the most curses and some of the harshest. Some people think this psalm is too harsh for the Bible. But this psalm has been seen as both prophetic and messianic by scholars like Chrysostom, Jerome, Augustine, and others.

Thomas Horne writes the past tenses of this psalm as future tenses, making it a prophetic text. His inspiration was Peter's quotation of Psalm 109:8 when picking a successor for Judas (Acts 1:20). The psalm speaks about the trials of Jesus, which makes it predictive of Christ rather than imprecatory.

Another troubling passage is Psalm 137:8–9, which happily speaks of the violent death of Babylonian children. Horne believed this was a prediction of the invasion of Babylon in 539 BC.

These psalms calling for justice are not at odds with the rest of the Bible. Jeremiah prayed for revenge (Jeremiah 11:20). He was answered by the Lord (verses 21–23). The righteous seeking justice will be answered (Luke 18:1–8). In Revelation, the martyrs call out, "How long, O Lord, holy and true, until You avenge our blood and judge those who dwell upon the earth?" (Revelation 6:10). Their cries are answered. David defeated his enemies, and he saw his enemies as the enemies of God. The enemies of the psalmist should receive judgment. The desires of the writer aligned with the judgment of God.

See also Judgment; Psalms, Book of; Wrath of God.

Imputation

Imputation means charging to an account. It is used in the Bible with legal reference to sin and salvation being recorded by God. The teaching on imputation is a key part of the Christian faith.

Imputation in the Bible

Although the noun "imputation" does not appear in the Bible, the verb "to impute" is often found in both the Old and New Testaments. The basic meaning of "impute" is "to record in a ledger or account." In the context of salvation, the word is consistently used in a legal sense. A good example of this is in Philemon 1:18, where the apostle Paul takes on the debt of Onesimus, saying, "if he ... owes you anything, charge it to my account."

When the Bible talks about imputing good or evil, it does not mean that a person's moral character changes. Instead, it means that, from God's perspective, righteousness or sin is credited to a person's account. In the broadest sense, the Bible teaches that both God Psalm 32:2) and people (1 Samuel 22:15) participate in this process. Good deeds were often credited for reward (Psalm 106:30–31), while evil deeds were credited for punishment (Leviticus 17:3–4).

Three Ways the Bible Explains Imputation

The Bible explains imputation in three main ways:

1. Adam's original sin is imputed to all people. In God's plan, Adam's first sin was credited to every person. So, everyone shares in the guilt and penalty of that sin.
2. The sin and guilt of all people were imputed to Christ. Although Jesus was sinless, he took on the penalty for sin.
3. The Bible teaches that Christ's righteousness is credited to believers because of his work on the cross. Even though believers are not perfectly holy, they are justified (declared right with God) before God's law and are clothed (that is, covered like a garment) with Christ's righteousness.

Imputation and Salvation

Paul explained that Christ took the punishment for believers' sins on the cross. He wrote that God "made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf" (2 Corinthians 5:21). Paul also said that Christ took on the curse of the Mosaic law (Galatians 3:13). Peter, reflecting on Isaiah 53, said that Christ "bore our sins in His body on the tree" (1 Peter 2:24). The idea that the world's guilt was placed on the sinless Savior helps explain Christ's cry on the cross, "My God, My God, why have You forsaken Me?" (Matthew 27:46).

Imputation also means that Christ's righteousness is credited to believers. An example from Abraham's life illustrates this. After God promised Abraham blessings, Genesis 15:6 says that Abraham "believed the LORD, and it was credited to him as righteousness." The Bible teaches that no person naturally has the level of righteousness God demands (Psalm 130:3; Isaiah 64:6; Romans 3:10). But in his salvation plan, God provides the needed righteousness (Isaiah 45:24; 54:17; Hosea 10:12). When a person accepts Christ's work by faith, God credits Christ's righteousness to them.

The imputation of divine righteousness to believers is a major theme in Paul's Letter to the Romans (Romans 3:21–5:21). Paul talks about the joy of a sinner who is declared righteous (Romans 4:6). The imputation of Christ's righteousness also leads to justification in God's law court (Romans 5:18). Christ's death, credited to the sinner, is the reason for acquittal by the holy God. The Bible teaches that the harmful effects of Adam's sin, which were imputed to humanity, are reversed for those who believe in Christ. The imputation of human sin to Christ allows his righteousness to be credited to believers.

See also Adam (Person); Christology; Fall of Man; Sin.

Imrah

Imrah was Zophah's son, a chief of the tribe of Asher (1 Chronicles 7:36, 40).

Imri

1. Ancestor of Uthai, one of the postexilic Jews of Judah's tribe (1 Chr 9:4). In the genealogy of Nehemiah 11:4, Imri and Amariah are probably the same person.
2. Father of Zaccur, a rebuilder of the Jerusalem wall (Neh 3:2).

Incantation

An incantation is a chant used in magic.

See Magic.

Incarnation

Literally, "in flesh"; theologically, the doctrine that in Jesus of Nazareth God took on human flesh and became the God-man. Historically, the doctrine of incarnation was central in the christological debates of patristic times and has recently come to the fore again in academic circles. Biblically, it expresses the mystery of Jesus' identity.

New Testament Testimony

The Synoptic Gospels

The Gospel of Mark has no account of the Incarnation and stresses Jesus' messiahship more than his deity. As a result, some believe that it represents an earlier stage in the development of the church's theology,

before the doctrine of incarnation had evolved. That is doubtful for two reasons: Incarnation passages like the Philippians hymn (Phil 2:6–11) probably antedate Mark's Gospel, and Mark has a well-developed theology of the two natures of Christ. Although he stresses Jesus' humanity, Mark accents it with an emphasis on divinity. Jesus was called the "beloved Son" by a heavenly voice at his baptism and transfiguration (Mk 1:11; 9:7); demons called him divine (3:11; 5:7), as did a Roman centurion (15:39). Jesus' "Abba" prayers (14:36; cf. Mt 26:39; Lk 22:42) indicate his sense of divine identity, and at his trial he was charged with claiming the title "Son of the Blessed" (14:61–62). Thus, though the Incarnation is nowhere explicitly stated in Mark, it is implicitly affirmed.

Matthew and Luke express the Incarnation. The birth narratives, of course, stress the event itself, with Matthew emphasizing Jesus' royal messiahship, and Luke, the divine witness of the Holy Spirit. Matthew's Gospel is Christ-centered; Luke concentrates on Christ as Savior, or more precisely, on salvation-history. Although Matthew presents Jesus' humanity, he emphasizes his lordship (Mt 23:6–10) and divine sonship. The Incarnation thus becomes the means whereby the divine becomes human in a universal sense (1:23; 18:20; 24:14; 28:18–20). Luke shows the greatest interest of the three in Jesus' earthly life. Nevertheless, his Gospel does not stress the human side of Jesus as much as Mark's. Luke portrays Jesus primarily as the divine Savior within history (Lk 2:11; 4:16–30). He combines Jesus' messianic office and divine nature, showing that the incarnate Son of God suffered and was exalted in order to bring people to God.

John's Writings

The apostle John's doctrine of incarnation is more explicit than any of the others, teaching not only Jesus' God-man status but also his preexistent "glory" (Jn 1:1–18). Central in this presentation is the oneness between Jesus and God the Father (10:29–30; 14:8–11; 1 Jn 2:23). The "I am" (the expressed Christ, taken from the OT title for the one true God and probably signifying God's personal name, Yahweh) came to reveal God to his people (Jn 1:4–5, 14, 18). Yet John also has the most balanced presentation of the Incarnation. The divine Logos or Word (1:1–18) is the exemplar of perfect humanity; he "became flesh" (v 14) to enlighten people (vv 5, 9) and generate in them "eternal life" (3:14–18; 1 Jn 1:1–3; 4:9).

Paul's Epistles

The apostle Paul presented the Incarnation as Jesus' path to suffering and redemption. In Galatians 4:4–5 the Incarnation ("born of woman") came "in the fullness of time" or at the apex of salvation-history, to "redeem those who were under the law." In the Philippians hymn (Phil 2:6–11, quotes from nasb), the Incarnation is seen in terms of preexistence ("though he was in the form of God"), humiliation ("emptied . . . humbled"), and obedience ("becoming obedient to the point of death"). The goal of the Incarnation was the cross ("even death on a cross"), and its result was Christ's exaltation. The hymn is perhaps the supreme theological statement on the Incarnation in the NT. Jesus' human life was an "emptying," a refusal to seize the prerogatives of his deity ("did not regard equality with God a thing to be grasped").

Paul described Christ as a second Adam (Rom 5:12–19; 1 Cor 15:45–47), who brought humanity a new possibility to attain what Adam had forsaken. Through assuming the form of a man, Christ became the Redeemer who reconciles people to God (Rom 3:25; 2 Cor 5:19; 1 Tm 1:15). Paul stressed even more, however, that the exalted Christ provides newness of life (Rom 6:4–6; 2 Cor 3:17–18; Col 3:1–4). A hymn in the Letter to the Colossians (1:15–20) employs ideas from Jewish wisdom speculation, and possibly Greek themes, to show Christ as the "firstborn" and the "fullness of God." The one who always existed as God, through his sacrificial death, became the exalted Lord and brought humankind to God (see also the "flesh-spirit" theme in Rom 1:3–4; 1 Tm 3:16).

Hebrews

The Letter to the Hebrews strongly speaks of the Incarnation. The opening hymn (Heb 1:1–3) accents Christ's exalted status as "the very stamp" of God's image and the radiance of his glory. Christ is superior to the angels (1:4–9), yet he became a man in order to suffer for human salvation (2:9; 5:7–9). The Incarnation is aligned with sinful humankind's need for a Savior. The purpose of Hebrews is to show Christ's incomparable superiority to the OT sacrifices, and at the same time to stress his work of salvation. His real temptation (2:18; 4:15) combined with his sinlessness (4:15; 5:9; 7:26) is the human remedy for human sin. The Incarnation was Christ's path to final, once-for-all atonement and victory over sin (7:28; 9:26).

Historical Development

The first group to challenge the traditional doctrine of incarnation was the Gnostics, who in the late first century denied that Jesus was truly human. Their Greek belief that the physical creation was evil led them to deny the Incarnation. They believed Christ to be a quasi-spiritual being who merely appeared human. The theologian Marcion (d. c. 160), trained by Gnostic teachers, also accepted a docetic interpre-

tation of Christ (his humanity was only apparent). Marcion taught his doctrine as an antidote to the OT or Jewish-oriented Christianity in his day. After his excommunication in AD 144, Marcion founded his own church, and his views were widely disseminated in the next two centuries. Partly in reaction to Marcion's christological heresy, the orthodox churches unified their doctrine.

The next challenge to the orthodox view came through the Arian, Apollinarian, and Nestorian controversies in the third and fourth centuries. Arianism held that the Incarnation was total, so that Christ the Logos was no longer fully God. At the same time, he was not fully human, so Christ was someone between two natures. The Council of Nicaea (AD 325) affirmed that Jesus was indeed both God and man. A further question soon arose, however, as to the relation between his two natures. Apollinarius (310?–390?) taught that only the body of Jesus was human; his soul was absorbed completely into the divine Logos. Nestorius (c. 381–451) taught that the two natures must always remain distinct in the person of Christ; they functioned together but were separate in his being. The Council of Chalcedon (AD 451) affirmed the unity of the two natures in Jesus. Many opponents of Chalcedon arose, called Monophysites, who believed in one divine nature in Jesus, who was only in a sense human. That movement caused serious political and religious divisions, and the Council of Constantinople (680–81) reaffirmed Chalcedon and established the orthodox incarnation theology.

In the eighth century, Spain and France were centers of the "adoptionist" controversy. Adoptionism taught that at birth Jesus was human, but at his baptism he underwent a "second birth" and was "adopted" as Son of God. It was condemned in a series of synods and never gained many adherents until modern times. During the scholastic age, Peter Lombard (1095?–1160) advocated what became known as "nihilism." The Incarnation supposedly caused no fundamental change in Jesus' deity, but his human nature was both insubstantial and unessential. That view likewise was condemned by Pope Alexander III (1159–81). Another debate at that time centered on the relationship between the fall and the Incarnation. Thomas Aquinas (1224–74) concluded that there was a cause-effect connection; the Incarnation was necessitated by sin rather than predestined apart from the fall.

The Roman Catholic Church and the Protestant Reformers follow basically the same orthodox teaching about the Incarnation. The conflict in the Reformation centered more on soteriology (the doctrine of salvation). Several aberrant antitrinitarian movements took advantage of the breakdown in ecclesiastical authority, however. Michael Servetus (1511–53) taught a pantheistic view of the Incarnation, focused on the divine Spirit becoming manifest in the human form of Jesus. Thus the Logos is not a distinct person in the Godhead, nor is it fundamentally different from a "divine spark" in every person. At the same time Laelius Socinus (1525–62) and his nephew, Faustus Socinus (1539–1604), taught a unitarian system. The Incarnation was not a transferral of the divine essence but a communication of divine authority and revelation. Christ thus did not die as an atonement but as a moral example. Both Servetus and Socinianism were condemned by Catholics and Protestants alike.

In the 17th and 18th centuries "kenoticism" (from Greek for "empty") taught that in the Incarnation the Logos totally "emptied himself" (Phil 2:7) of the divine attributes. That doctrine represented the final phase of a dialogue from the scholastic period about the exact communication between Jesus' two natures. Was his human nature omnipotent? If not, how did the man Jesus exercise the divine attributes? The kenotic school believed that Jesus was fully human and that his divine nature was quiescent until after the Ascension. His miraculous powers were external, given by the Spirit. Against that view, the majority of theologians argued that Jesus was at all times both God and man, and that in Philippians 2:6–8 Jesus did not lay aside the attributes of deity (he still exhibited the "form of God") but rather the majesty associated with deity.

The 19th and 20th centuries have given rise to a view that the Incarnation was a "myth," a pictorial way of describing how God spoke through Jesus. The virgin birth was not historical, nor did any of the supernatural events of the Gospels ever take place. Rather, the stories in the Gospels were concoctions of the later church, efforts to portray Jesus' impact on the movement. The Gospels, however, have too strong a flavor of accurate history for such a view to prevail (see Lk 1:1–5; Jn 19:35; 21:24).

Conclusion

The NT teaching on the Incarnation balances the humanity and divinity of Christ. Those two facts must harmonize in any theological system, for both are absolutely necessary parts of God's redemptive plan. In the Incarnation, Jesus became a perfect human being. As God in human flesh, he suffered the divine penalty for sin as an innocent substitute. Being both God and man, Jesus simultaneously revealed God's will for human life and reconciled sinful people to God

through his own perfect life and death. Because of the Incarnation, therefore, those who believe in Christ have peace with God and new life from God.

See also Christology; Jesus Christ, Life and Teachings of; Genealogy of Jesus Christ; Virgin Birth of Jesus.

Incense

Sweet-smelling spices and oils or sacrifices that produce pleasant-smelling smoke that satisfies God.

Since time began, people have loved pleasant smells. In ancient times, sacrifices included sweet smells to satisfy the gods. The smell was important for the gods to accept the offering. Thus, sweet-smelling plants and exotic-smelling liquids (perfumes) were valuable for both everyday and religious uses.

People valued spices and precious oils as well as silver and gold. The Queen of Sheba gave spices to King Solomon as a gift (1 Kings 10:2). The royal treasury stored incense (2 Kings 20:13). Spices and oils were very expensive because of the hard work of extracting them. It also cost a lot to import them from distant places. Merchants made high profits from selling the perfumes.

As a result, wives sometimes compared their beloved husband to "myrrh," a "mountain of myrrh," and a "hill of frankincense" (Song of Solomon 1:13; 4:6). The sweet smell of incense created the right atmosphere (1:12). Every spice known to a merchant burned beside King Solomon's large bed (couch) (3:6).

A husband enjoyed the perfumes of his beloved wife. She was his own private garden of incense (4:10–14). Even a prostitute burned incense beside her bed (Ezekiel 23:41). It is no surprise that wise men said, "Oil and incense bring joy to the heart, and the counsel of a friend is sweetness to the soul" (for example, Proverbs 27:9).

Types of Incense

Frankincense is the incense mentioned most often in the Bible. They imported it from India, Somaliland, and Arabia Felix. Myrrh also came from Arabia Felix. Cinnamon was another important fragrance from Ceylon and China. Galbanum, tragacanth (a type of gum), and laudanum all grew in the mountains of Asia Minor. Galbanum was the most popular of these three because it was also found in Turkestan, Persia, Syria, and Crete. Henna, saffron, and balsam came from sweet-smelling plants native to Israel.

After the Jewish exile to Babylon, other plants came to Palestine, and they cultivated them there. These included the rose, narcissus, and jasmine. They seemed to have produced Onycha from local animals. Perhaps they extracted musk from a gland of the musk deer.

Incense came in many forms. People might use grains in a bag hung around the neck (Song of Solomon 1:13). However, most perfumes were liquid, dissolved in olive oil. A good example is the "sacred anointing oil" (Exodus 30:31). People used these oils to anoint the priests and kings of Israel. Only priests could prepare and use them. The incense contained raw spices beaten into a fine powder and seasoned with salt to make them holy.

They mixed equal parts of stacte, onycha, galbanum, and pure frankincense, "the work of a perfumer" (Exodus 30:34–37). People donated spices and incense for the sanctuary as gifts (Numbers 7:14–86; Jeremiah 17:26; 41:5). They stored them in the temple (Nehemiah 13:5, 9). Josephus described the incense of his time as a more complex mixture. He listed 13 ingredients in the best incense of the Herodian era.

Incense Offering

Archaeology shows that incense offerings were common in the ancient Near East from the start of organized worship. Egyptian paintings and reliefs (raised surface art) from the New Kingdom sometimes depict a man holding a censer with burning incense. Assyria, Babylonia, and Arabia also used incense in their ceremonies. Altars from Canaan found at Megiddo and Tell Beit Mirsim have limestone altars with horns from the 10th century BC. It is possibly designed to hold a bowl of incense. Therefore, it is reasonable to assume that incense offerings were part of Israel's worship from the beginning.

Incense offerings served several purposes in Israel's worship. Incense was closely associated with holiness and prayer, and it marked sacred space as belonging to God. In some rituals, incense was connected with the consecration of the place of worship and its furnishings (Exodus 30:26–29). The Bible often describes offerings as producing a "pleasing aroma" to the Lord. This phrase expresses God's acceptance of the offering, not a physical smell meant to please humans.

In some cases, incense itself became a sacrifice. In addition to other sacrifices, people burned frankincense alone. To stop a plague, Aaron performed a ceremony by burning incense (Numbers 16:46–47).

On the Day of Atonement, the high priest carried burning incense and hot coals on a censer (a pan that held incense) into the Holy of Holies (Leviticus 16:12–13). People believed the burning incense protected the high priest's life. It was possibly because the smoke prevented him from seeing the full glory of God.

People added frankincense to grain for offerings on the altar of burnt offering (Leviticus 2:1, 15–16; 6:15). It also accompanied the bread of the Presence in two dishes (24:7). King Hezekiah destroyed the bronze serpent during his reform. This was because it had become a polluted object to which people burned incense (2 Kings 18:4).

Except on the Day of Atonement, they offered incense on a special altar (Leviticus 4:7; see also Exodus 30:9). It burned morning and evening and became known as "perpetual incense" (Exodus 30:7–8). The altar of gold in King Solomon's temple was probably the incense altar (1 Kings 6:20–22).

Offering incense was a holy ceremony. People who did not follow the procedures encountered punishment (Leviticus 10:1–2; Numbers 16:6–50). Uzziah, King of Judah, became a leper because he wrongly tried to offer incense (2 Chronicles 26:16–21).

Burning incense at "high places" often encountered criticism (for example, 1 Kings 22:43). This was either because the holy places were where they worshiped false gods or the priests did not care as much as those in Jerusalem. Prophets who criticized incense offerings did so to condemn ceremonies that lacked true dedication to the God of Israel (Isaiah 1:13; 66:3; Jeremiah 6:20).

Meaning of Incense

Incense was a precious item, making it a suitable offering to God (Malachi 1:11). Incense offerings gave people a way to experience God's holy presence and seek forgiveness for sins (Numbers 16:46–47). The smoke rising to the sky symbolized people's prayers (Psalm 141:2; Luke 1:10; Revelation 5:8; 8:3–4). In the temple, the smoke also represented God's presence. This was similar to the cloud in the wilderness (Exodus 19:18; 33:9–10; Numbers 11:25). Along with the rising sun, the smoke was a strong symbol of the Lord's glory (Isaiah 6:1–7).

New Testament mentions of incense further enhance the importance of incense. A Christian's testimony about Christ is like offering incense (2 Corinthians 2:14–15). The sweet smell of the gospel contrasts with the smell of death that leads to destruction. Similarly, money from the Philippian Christians reached Paul like an incense sacrifice, showing love and devotion (Philippians 4:18).

Finally, incense seems to purify and accompany the prayers of the saints into God's presence (Revelation 5:8; 8:3–4). None of the New Testament references ask Christians to offer incense. At the least, these many passages encourage learning dedication to holy living, symbolized by burning this precious substance.

See also Plants (Aloe; Balm; Calamus; Cinnamon; Frankincense; Galbanum; Henna; Hyssop; Myrrh; Nard; Storax Tree); Perfume; Tabernacle; Temple.

Incest

Sexual relations between close relatives.

Incest is strongly forbidden in Leviticus 18. Leviticus 20 even says some kinds of incest should be punished by death. The Bible treats incest as a very serious offense, calling it dishonorable and perverted.

Examples of incest in the Bible show it comes from bad character:

- Lot's daughters got their father drunk and slept with him. Both became pregnant (Genesis 19:30–38).
- Amnon tricked and forced himself on his half-sister Tamar (2 Samuel 13:1–22) .
- Paul strongly criticized incest happening in the Corinthian church (1 Corinthians 5:1–5), showing it was still wrong in New Testament times.

Blood relationship, or consanguinity, is one reason for illegal sexual contact. This applies, for example, to brothers and sisters, parents and children, grandparents and grandchildren, as well as some aunts, uncles, nieces, and nephews. Leviticus 18 also forbids sex with relatives by marriage (affinity) and some aunts and uncles. In ancient Israel, there was one exception: a man could marry his dead brother's widow if she had no son (Deuteronomy 25:5–10).

While there are genetic reasons to avoid incest among blood relatives, the main problem is that it hurts families. Since families are central to God's work on earth, he judges incest very harshly. Families can't survive when there's sexual misconduct among their members.

India

An eastern land of inconsistent geographical borders in Bible times. The Bible only mentions India in Esther 1:1 and 8:9.

Ahasuerus's empire stretched from Hoddu to Kush. The term "Hoddu"seems to come from an Old Persian word, Hindush. It was related to a Sanskrit word, Sindhu, meaning "stream." This refers to the Indus River.

Inscriptions from Persia show that India was a province of the Achaemenid Empire from 559 to 330 BC. This supports the biblical statements in Esther.

Even the Greek historian Herodotus in the fifth century BC seems to have been poorly informed about India (Persian Wars 3.94–106; 4.40, 44).

Some Hebrew legends and traditions mention Jews in India in the days of King Solomon. Some interpreters have suggested that the Pishon river in the land of Havilah may refer to India (Genesis 2:11). Some say that goods from Ophir, like sandalwood ("almug wood," 1 Kings 10:11; 2 Chronicles 2:8), ivory, and apes, were Indian in origin. Also, some of the items carried by merchants to Tyre, such as ivory tusks and ebony (Ezekiel 27:15), may have come from India.

The New Testament does not reference India. However, Jewish writings from before and after the New Testament refer to the land. These include the Targums on Esther, the Midrashim, and the Talmud. It was only after Alexander the Great died in 323 BC that Palestine and Europe began to write about India. 1 Maccabees 6:37 says the Seleucid armies used war elephants (who were possibly from India), mounted by Indian drivers in the second century BC. 1 Maccabees 8:8 states that the Romans forced Antiochus III to surrender.

India's value is unclear due to textual issues. Moreover, there's no proof that the Seleucid Empire extended to India. However, the Romans traded in India via Egypt and the Red Sea. This makes the lack of references in the New Testament strange.

As the Christian centuries passed, references appeared in both Jewish and early Christian literature. It is certain that, early in the Christian era, there were settlements of Jews and monophysite Christians in India. Monophysitism is a belief that Jesus Christ had only one nature, which was divine, rather than both human and divine natures. According to legend, it was the apostle Thomas who took the gospel to India and founded the Mar Thoma Church.

Infirmity

Infirmity is an older word for physical weakness, sickness, or disability. In some Bible passages, it may also describe human weakness more generally.

See Disease; Medicine and Medical Practice.

Inheritance

Legacy or bequest. Inheritance plays an unusually significant role in the Scriptures when it is used to convey theological truths. As we might expect, these theological applications reflect legal customs in force during OT and NT times.

Legal and Historical Aspect

The Patriarchs

We learn something of early-second-millennium BC practices from the patriarchal stories in Genesis. For example, the narrative indicates that the firstborn could normally expect to receive the birthright. Yet exceptions abound. Ishmael (Gn 16:15; 17:15–21), Esau (25:23), and Reuben (49:3–4) did not receive the birthright. Another item of special interest is Abraham's suggestion that, in the absence of a son, his servant Eliezer might be regarded as the heir (15:2–5); scholars have found confirmation of this practice in Hurrian legal documents of the second millennium.

The Hebrew Nation

According to Deuteronomy 21:15–17, Hebrew firstborns were legally entitled to a double portion of the inheritance. Israelite law also made provision for widows through the practice of levirate marriage (Dt 25:5; see Gn 38:8; Ru 4:5).

According to Numbers 27:1–11, the daughters of Zelophehad argued that they should receive the inheritance since their father had died without sons. Consequently, God decreed that if a man died without sons, the inheritance should be transferred to his daughter; if he had no daughter, to his brothers; if he had no brothers, to his nearest relatives. This particular incident also illustrates the importance of preserving tribal possessions: the daughters of Zelophehad were not allowed to marry outside the tribe of Manasseh, for this would mean transferral of the property to another tribe (Nm 36).

How highly the Israelites valued their family's inherited possessions may be gathered from Leviticus 25:25–28. If an individual sold his land for financial reasons, provision must be made for a relative to redeem it; if he had no near relative, he could still purchase it back at a later time, and even if he could not afford to do so, the land automatically reverted to him in the Year of Jubilee, when all debts were canceled (note also Lv 27:14–25).

In the New Testament

Apart from the reference to levirate marriage in Matthew 22:23–33 (Mk 12:18–27; Lk 20:27–40), the NT has little to say about principles of property transferral during Roman times.

In the parable of the prodigal son, the younger son in the family requested his share of the inheritance (Lk 15:12). One should also note that the elder son, who with false piety looked down on his brother's behavior, had not protested when his brother asked for the inheritance; on the contrary, the elder brother too,

without complaining, received his share—presumably a double portion.

In another significant passage (Gal 4:1–2) Paul, seeking to illustrate a theological point, refers to secular practices. An heir, he tells us, is subject to guardians and managers during his childhood, up to the time he actually inherits. The point Paul wants to establish is clear enough, but the illustration does not coincide with what we know of Roman law and unfortunately scholars have been unable to identify the precise social custom in view. It may be that Paul was making reference, in general rather than strict legal terms, to some practice with which he and the Galatians were familiar.

Theological Aspect

Canaan as Israel's Inheritance

The conviction that God gave Palestine to the Israelites for their inheritance serves as a bridge between the historical and the theological data. The historical element lies in the obvious fact that the Promised Land, a physical entity, was certainly occupied by the Hebrews and distributed among their tribes. Theologically, however, the Scriptures speak of this occupation as a divine gift; in effect, even the method of distribution was based on the concept that the land belongs to God (Lv 25:23; see Ex 15:17; Jos 22:27; Ez 38:16; Jl 1:6).

The theme goes back to Genesis 12:1–3. God, in choosing Abraham, instructed him to move to a new country and promised to make him a great and blessed nation (Heb 11:8). The significance of the land in this Abrahamic promise is made more explicit later, when we are told that God promised to give Canaan to Abraham's descendants after four centuries of Egyptian bondage (Gn 15:12–21; see Acts 7:5).

Since Canaan was occupied by wicked inhabitants, the land was to be taken by force; to inherit the land therefore really means to take possession of it. Israel must trust God, whose land it is, to give them the victory (Jos 1:1–9; 21:43–45; Jgs 7:2; Ps 44:1–3; Acts 13:19). Once they conquered the land, it was apportioned among the tribes according to their size (following the instructions in Nm 26:52–54). God further commanded the people to divide the land by lot (vv 55–56). Thus, from the initial promise to Abraham, to the actual apportionment of the land and even with reference to the future (Is 60:21; Ez 45:1–8; 47:13–48:29), the people were made fully aware that their inheritance lay in the hands of a sovereign Lord.

The Believer's Inheritance

In the OT we find the concept of inheritance transferred from the purely physical to the spiritual. The tribe of Levi, which constituted the priestly clan, received no inheritance, because "the Lord is their inheritance" (Dt 18:1–2; see Nm 18:8–24). The Levites, in other words, received no land apportionment, but in their service to God they could begin to enjoy the fuller blessings to which the land inheritance pointed.

That this truth could not be restricted to Levites is hinted at in Exodus 19:6, where the whole nation is called "a kingdom of priests" (see 1 Pt 2:9). Psalm 16 makes it clear that no one understood more clearly than David what those words entailed. Even if he were deprived of Israel's physical inheritance, he had received by lot a more beautiful heritage, the Lord himself, in whose presence he found full joy and everlasting pleasures (Ps 16:5–6, 11; see also Pss 73:25–26; 142:5; Is 58:14; Lam 3:24).

In later Judaism, during and after the intertestamental period, the figure was extended considerably. For example, the rabbis began to speak of the law as the inheritance of the faithful. Further, they might give the idea a negative turn, as when the wicked are said to inherit hell (cf. Jb 27:13). Neither of these figures is found in the NT.

We also read in Jewish literature statements about inheriting the age to come, the kingdom, eternal life; these ideas occur frequently in the NT (Mt 19:29; 25:34; Lk 10:25; 18:18; 1 Cor 6:9–10; 15:50; Gal 5:21; Eph 5:5; Ti 3:7; Jas 2:5). Such an inheritance, however, belongs only to those who are sanctified by God's word (Acts 20:32; 26:18; Col 1:12; note also Jn 17:17; Col 3:23–24). These future blessings do not exclude the physical (Mt 5:5; note Ps 37:11, 29; Is 60:21; Rom 4:13; 2 Pt 3:13), but they certainly exclude human frailty, for God's inheritance is imperishable (1 Cor 15:50). In short, our heritage is nothing less than full salvation (Heb 1:14; 11:7), which God carefully guards for us in heaven (1 Pt 1:4).

Doubtless, the most significant feature in the NT is its emphasis that, as a result of the work of Christ, his people begin even now to receive the promised inheritance. The Gospel of John frequently stresses the present reality of eternal life, as does the Letter to the Hebrews (cf. 6:12–17 with 9:15 and 11:13, 39–40).

Paul treats this whole matter thoroughly in Galatians 3:7–4:7. In response to the Judaizers, who claim that the Abrahamic inheritance is restricted to those who become Jews through circumcision, Paul argues vigorously that Abraham's true children are those who

believe, whether Jew or Gentile (3:7; see Acts 26:16–18; Eph 3:6). They become heirs of God's promise, for they receive the Spirit (Gal 3:14). The principle of inheritance is promise, not the Law (v 18). Those who believe are brought into union with Christ (vv 27–29); but then they are not merely Abraham's children but God's (v 26), for Christ is the Son of God and God has determined to send the Spirit of his Son to believers so that they too may call God Father (Gal 4:4–7; see also Rom 8:15–16).

Indeed, Christ himself as the Son is the true heir (Mt 21:38; Mk 12:7; Lk 20:14); he has inherited a name above every name (Phil 2:9; Heb 1:4) and has been appointed heir of all things (Heb 1:2; see Ps 2:7–8; Mt 28:18). But by his grace, all who become his through faith are counted joint heirs with him (Rom 8:17).

God's Inheritance

With a bold shift in the metaphor, the Scriptures speak of believers as God's inheritance. In the beautiful "Song of Moses" the author speaks of God as the Israelites' Father (Dt 32:6), who has taken special interest in their inheritance (v 8). Then we are told why God cares: "For the Lord's portion is his people, Jacob his allotted inheritance" (Dt 32:9, niv). This theme becomes very prominent throughout the OT (e.g., Dt 9:26–29; 1 Kgs 8:51–53; Pss 28:9; 33:12; 74:2; Is 19:25; Jer 10:16; Zec 2:12). Elsewhere, Israel is spoken of as God's special possession (e.g., Ex 19:5; Dt 7:6).

In Ephesians 1:14 "the redemption of the possession" refers to the final salvation of believers, who are God's treasure. Further, "we have obtained an inheritance" (Eph 1:11) may well be translated, "we have been made an inheritance," that is, been "chosen as God's portion," a view supported by verse 18. No more fundamental idea than this can be found in Scripture, and its essence is expressed by the words of the One who sits on the throne: "He who conquers shall have this heritage, and I will be his God and he shall be my son" (Rv 21:7, rsv; see Lv 26:11–12; 2 Sm 7:14).

See also Adoption; Birthright; Firstborn; Heir.

Iniquity

Iniquity is a term used in the Bible to describe serious wrongdoing or sin.

See Sin.

Ink, Inkhorn

An ink is a liquid used for writing, usually black or dark colored. An inkhorn is a small container made from an animal horn that was used to hold ink in ancient times.

See Writing.

Inn

An inn is a place where travelers can stay overnight while on a journey. Inns have changed over time, from simple shelters to places more like today's hotels.

Inns in the Old Testament

The word "inn" occurs three times in older Bible translations (like the King James Version) in the Old Testament. Two of the occurrences are when Joseph's brothers rest overnight during their trips between Egypt and Canaan (Genesis 42:27; 43:21). The third occurrence is when Moses returns to Egypt from Midian to lead the children of Israel (Exodus 4:24).

The Berean Standard Version translates each of these instances as "lodging place." In the time of Abraham and Moses, the Near East did not have inns as we know them today. Our idea of an inn is a public place where travelers can pay to stay.

In settled areas, a traveler could usually expect local people to offer them a place to stay. Across the Near East, offering a place to stay was seen as an important duty (see Genesis 19:1–3; Judges 19:15–21). In empty areas, travelers would make their own shelter (Genesis 28:11). They would also bring their own food (Joshua 9:11–13).

We do not know exactly when real inns started in Palestine. Some think they came from other countries, as the Jewish words for "inn" come from Greek and Latin. Old texts such as the Targum and Josephus (Antiquities 5.1.12) call Rahab an innkeeper (Joshua 2:1). But, there may not have been inns in Joshua's time. However, there are parallels in the Near East of women keeping an establishment providing both rooms and sexual activity for travelers.

Inns in the New Testament

We know Greek inns existed as early as the 5th century BC. They became common in the areas influenced by Greek culture. These inns were usually uncomfortable and unsafe.

This kind of inn with an innkeeper is where the Good Samaritan took the man who was robbed (Luke 10:34–35). This inn was probably much like a khan (a small inn inside of towns) or caravansary (a larger inn on the edge of a town, especially along trade routes). These would have been common along the trade routes in Syria for a long time.

These inns were square buildings with an open area in the middle where water and shelter were available,

but travelers usually brought their own food and sometimes their own bedding. The Good Samaritan clearly expected the host to take care of the hurt man. It is difficult to tell if this was normal or just because it was an emergency.

The inn in the story Jesus told about the Good Samaritan has long been identified with the Khan Hathrur. It is located halfway between Jerusalem and Jericho. Though the present structure is probably only one of many built in the same place.

Two other well-known parts of the New Testament talk about different kinds of places to stay:

1. Christians from Rome met Paul, who was a prisoner, at Three Taverns, a stopping place 53 kilometers (33 miles) from Rome, where the two roads met (Acts 28:15).
2. There is the inn that had no room for Joseph and Mary (Luke 2:7). This word is also translated as "guestchamber" (King James Version) and "guest room" (Mark 14:14; Luke 22:11, Berean Standard Bible).

The Jews in Jerusalem were proud that they had enough guest rooms for all the visitors who came for Passover. This is also true for the crowd at Pentecost (Acts 2:6–11). It seems Joseph and Mary expected to find a place like this in Bethlehem for the census, but all the rooms were taken.

See also Travel.

Inner Man

The inner, invisible being of a human. This Pauline phrase resembles the "hidden man" (kjv) of 1 Peter 3:4 (cf. Rom 2:29), where outward appearance is contrasted with inward reality. It assumes the current Jewish conception of man as a unitary being having both observable and invisible aspects, a physical body including a "psychological" heart. Paul says his members submit to sin's rule even while his "inmost self" (rsv) delights in divine law (Rom 7:22). In Romans 8:13, he speaks of setting the mind on things of the flesh versus things of the Spirit, describing this same conflict between the inner and outer man.

This inner core of personality is already the locus where the Spirit's strength is instilled and where Christ dwells in the Christian. So another contrast is between the mortal and already decaying outward man, weakened by age and by sharing the dying of Christ, and the daily renewed inner man, as the life of the risen Jesus is manifested in mortal flesh (2 Cor 4:10–16). Taken with Romans 8:11, this may possibly echo a speculation of intertestamental Judaism that a spiritual counterpart to the present body is already being prepared by the quickening of divine life in the devout inner man.

See also Man.

Inscriptions

Term used to refer to writing in the ancient world that was done on a material of a permanent nature, such as stone or clay, rather than on ordinary and impermanent substances, such as papyri or parchment.

Preview

- Introduction
- Inscriptions on Monuments
- Historical Records
- Official Announcements
- Dedications
- Correspondence
- Mosaic Floor Decorations

Introduction

There are occasional references to inscriptions in the Bible; for example, the Ten Commandments were inscribed on stone (Ex 31:18) and given to Moses, and later written by Joshua on stone and set up at Mt Ebal near Shechem (Jos 8:32). In the excavations at Shechem, G. E. Wright found a large stone prepared to receive an inscription that he dated to the time of Joshua on stratigraphic grounds. It may still be seen at the site. A message from the hand of God to the Babylonian king Belshazzar was inscribed on the walls of his palace (Dn 5:5, 24). Paul observed an altar with the inscription "To an unknown god" in the marketplace of Athens (Acts 17:23). The book of Revelation speaks of the names of the 12 tribes of the sons of Israel being inscribed on the gates of the heavenly city (Rv 21:12).

Inscriptions in the ancient world can be found in almost any language and from any period of history: Egyptian, Babylonian, Persian, Greek, Latin, Hebrew, Aramaic, Nabatean, Moabite, and so on. It was once popular to argue that Moses could not have written the Pentateuch because writing had not been invented that early. Inscriptions found at the turquoise mines of Serabit el-Khadim dating to the 15th century BC have disproven this allegation. In addition, it might be noted that clay tablets found at Ras Shamra by Claude Schaeffer and dated to about 1400 BC demonstrate a considerable period of literary activity, as do the tablets at Ebla from approximately 1,000 years earlier.

Inscriptions may be found in almost any position or place, but the most common locations are in the floors of synagogues, church buildings, and mosques; the pavements of forums; the walls of public buildings; dedicatory stones and statues; stelae and monumental plaques; tombs and sarcophagi; and Roman milestones. An exhaustive list is impossible, but a few representative samples will illustrate the various kinds of extant inscriptional material.

Inscriptions on Monuments

The Egyptian pharaoh Merneptah commemorated his victory over the Sea Peoples in the 13th century BC by inscribing a black granite stele with a record of his victory. It contains the earliest known reference to Israel outside the land of Palestine: "Israel lies desolate."

The Israelite king Omri (1 Kgs 16:16–30) is referred to in a text carved in the Moabite language on a stone dating near the end of the reign of the Moabite king Mesha, about 830 BC. It was found at Diban (OT Dibon) in 1868 and contains a record of the successful rebellion of the king against Israelite oppression.

Another monumental inscription was found in Persia carved into the steep slope of Mt Behistun. It is a trilingual (Old Persian, Elamite, Akkadian) record of the exploits of Darius I, providing the key to unlocking the mystery of the cuneiform script in which several of these ancient languages were written.

The Assyrian king Shalmaneser III left a record of his first six campaigns of conquest inscribed on a monolith found in 1861 at Kurkh on the Tigris. The stone is carved front and back in cuneiform that is written over a bas-relief of the king. This same king left a black stone obelisk, six and a half feet (2 meters) high, depicting his triumphs over several other kings, among whom is Jehu, king of Israel, depicted in the second panel from the top, prostrating himself before the Assyrian monarch. This is the earliest picture available of an Israelite and the only known representation of an Israelite king by a contemporary. The inscription above the picture reads, "The tribute of Jehu, son [descendant] of Omri . . ." It dates to the mid-ninth century BC.

Historical Records

Frequently in the region of Mesopotamia, ancient kings recorded important events or proclamations in stone or clay. A notable example is the clay prism containing the final edition of Sennacherib's Annals dated to 691 BC. It is hexagonal, 15 inches (38.1 centimeters) high and 6 inches (15.2 centimeters) wide, and written on all sides in cuneiform script. The inscription speaks of "Hezekiah the Jew (king of Judah), who did not submit to my yoke. . . . Like a caged bird, I shut him up in Jerusalem, his royal city" (cf. 2 Kgs 18; Is 36–39).

Even though no annals comparable to those produced by the Assyrian kings have survived among the Babylonians, we do have some chronicles written on clay tablets covering the years from 626 BC to the fall of Babylon to Cyrus in 539. One of these, the Babylonian Chronicle, provides an exact date of March 16, 597 BC, for the fall of Jerusalem to the Babylonian king Nebuchadnezzar (cf. 2 Kgs 24:10–17).

Babylon itself fell to Cyrus the Mede, king of Persia, in 539. The event is not only referred to in the Bible (Ezr 1:1–3) but is also described on a clay barrel-shaped cylinder nine inches (22.9 centimeters) in length, written in cuneiform script, during the reign of Cyrus. It refers to his policy that allowed captive nations to rebuild their cities and temples. This provides an explanation of his encouragement and financial help to the Jews in returning to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple of Solomon that Nebuchadnezzar had destroyed (Ezr 1:2–4).

Egyptian pharaohs were fond of publishing records of their exploits in hieroglyphic script on the walls of temples and tombs. These were usually incised into the stone and then painted. One of the most interesting is Shishak's description of his invasion of the land of Israel incised on the southern wall of a court of the temple of Amon at Karnak. The inclusion of Megiddo, as well as other cities in Israel, among the more than 75 cities whose names can still be read adds historical interest to the biblical account of Shishak's invasion and conquest of Jerusalem and "Judah's fortified cities" (1 Kgs 14:25–26; 2 Chr 12:2–10). Archaeological finds confirm a destruction and burning of the city at this time.

Official Announcements

When an ancient monarch or public official wanted to publish an announcement with some degree of permanency, it would be carved in stone or set in mosaic. An inscription on a marble slab dating to the reign of Claudius (AD 41–54) was found in 1878, originating in the city of Nazareth. It contains a warning against grave robbing or any other desecration of cemeteries. The penalty for such violation was declared to be death. The inscription may reflect some of the troubles Claudius had in Rome over the person of Christ (Suetonius, Claudius 25) which led to the expulsion of Jews from the capital city (Acts 18). At issue must have been the resurrection of Christ as proclaimed in Rome.

Announcements were placed even in temples. Josephus referred to a small wall surrounding the Jewish temple in Jerusalem that contained slabs of stone at regular intervals giving warning in Greek and Latin to Gentiles entering the temple (War 5.193–34; 6.125–26; Antiquities 15.417). Two fragmentary examples have been found. One discovered by Clermont-Ganneau in 1871 reads: "No foreigner is to enter within the balustrade and embankment around the sanctuary. Whoever is caught will have himself to blame for his death which follows." The Romans allowed the Jews to put anyone to death, even a Roman, who went beyond this barrier (War 6.126).

An important inscription commissioned by the emperor Claudius, was found at the beginning of the 20th century in Delphi, Greece. It was written in Greek and mentions Gallio as proconsul with a date that can be established as AD 51–52 for his term of office. This Gallio is the proconsul before whom Paul was brought by the Jews of Corinth (Acts 18:12–17). It is therefore extremely important for establishing the date of Paul's 18-month stay in Corinth, and an important pivotal date for Pauline chronology in general. The inscription is an imperial announcement to the citizens of Delphi regarding the need for increasing the population of the city with eminent people.

The name Pontius Pilate has appeared in a Latin inscription carved into a stone found in the Roman theater at Caesarea Maritima on the coast of Israel. It refers to him, in partially mutilated words, as prefect and contains the name Tiberium, which designates a structure built in honor of the emperor Tiberius.

Dedications

Inscriptions were commonly placed on walls or floors of buildings or attached to some other structure dedicating the completed edifice. An inscription was cut into the wall of a long tunnel built by the Jewish king Hezekiah in Jerusalem when the tunnel was finished (2 Kgs 20:20). It is in Hebrew and is now in the Istanbul museum. One of the oldest inscriptions we have in that language, it describes the construction of the Siloam tunnel.

In the city of Corinth in Greece there is a dedicatory inscription cut into the pavement of a plaza on the north side of the large theater. The abbreviated Latin inscription reads: Erastus pro aedilitate sua pecunia stravit ("Erastus, in return for his aedileship, laid the pavement at his own expense"). The bronze has long since been removed from the letters deeply cut into the gray Acrocorinthian limestone. This is probably the same "Erastus, the city treasurer" mentioned by Paul in Romans 16:23. A similar inscription from the Corinthian agora of Paul's day reads: "Gnaeus Babbius Philinus, aedile and pontifex, had this monument erected at his own expense, and he approved it in his official capacity as duovir."

A monumental dedicatory inscription in Greek was found in Jerusalem during excavations in 1913–14, which once stood on the wall of a first-century AD synagogue on Mt Ophel. It refers to a Theodotus, the son of a ruler of the synagogue named Vettenos, who built the synagogue. Since the name Vettenos is Roman, it may be that Theodotus was a Jewish slave who had been freed and given the Roman name of his master. If so, this inscription may have hung on the "synagogue of the Freedmen" in Jerusalem (Acts 6:9).

The British Museum contains a portion of a broken arch that stood over an entrance into the Greek city of Thessalonica from the first century AD until 1867, when it was torn down to provide stone for the repair of the vast city wall. The inscription begins: "In the time of the politarchs . . ." This is a rare word referring to Roman officials and is used in the book of Acts (Acts 17:6) in reference to city authorities of Thessalonica. This word is found nowhere else in Greek literature.

Correspondence

In the second millennium before Christ, it was common practice to write correspondence on small clay tablets. More than half a million have been found in Mari, Nuzi, Nineveh, Ebla, and elsewhere. Interesting examples of such correspondence may be found in a great number of clay tablets found at Tell el-Amarna in Upper Egypt. They were written in the Babylonian language using the cuneiform script during the time when Akhenaton was captivated with his reformation of Egyptian art and religion at his new capital Tell el-Amarna (Akhetaten), and Palestine and Syria were left to the mercy of marauders called Habiru in the documents. Many of these are written from cities in Canaan under attack and ask for help from the pharaoh, whose vassals they are at this time (late 14th century BC). Some think that these Habiru were the ancient Hebrews who invaded the land under the direction of Joshua.

Sometimes correspondence was written in ink on broken pieces of ceramic pottery (potsherds) called ostraca. In 1935, 18 of these were found in the excavations at Lachish in southern Israel. They are written in Hebrew and provide examples of the kind of script used by the Judeans in the time of Jeremiah. The language is essentially identical with the Hebrew of the OT. The letters were sent by Hosha'yahu, an officer

in charge of a nearby town, to Ya'osh, the military governor of Lachish, during the invasion of Judea by the Babylonians, which ended in the destruction of the temple in Jerusalem in 586 BC.

Eleven such potsherds were found in Masada, on the western shore of the Dead Sea, in excavations conducted by Yigael Yadin from 1963 to 1965. Masada was destroyed by the Roman army under the command of Flavius Silva in AD 73. Nine hundred and sixty men, women, and children committed suicide rather than surrender to the Romans. Ten men were chosen to cut the throats of those who remained. They drew lots for the heartbreaking task, according to Josephus (War 7.395), and Professor Yadin thinks the ostraca he found were the ones used in the drawing. One of them contained the name of Ben Yair, who was probably Eleazer ben Yair, the commander of the fortress.

Mosaic Floor Decorations

In the Roman and Byzantine periods it was popular to decorate the floors of basilicas, baths, synagogues, churches, and other public buildings with elaborate tesselation containing inscriptions and artwork. Excavation in 1972 disclosed a building in Caesarea Maritima with mosaic inscriptions in six floors throughout the structure. Two of them are the Greek text of Romans 13:3 set in a circular border. Another is a blessing on the one who enters and exits the room: "May the Lord bless your entry and your exit." Two of them invoke the aid of Christ for people associated with the function and construction of the building. These were a part of a building that was destroyed in the seventh century AD.

The floors of the synagogues at Tiberias-hamath, Beth Shan, Beth Alpha, Eshtemoa, Susiya, Hamath-gader, En-gedi, and others in Israel have inscriptions in Greek and Aramaic that usually refer to benefactors of the synagogue. A synagogue floor has been found in Naro, Tunisia, which contains a Latin inscription. In the Tiberias synagogue, Hebrew was used only for defining the astrological symbols that appear in the zodiac. Aramaic was used primarily for Halakah (religious rule or law), and Greek was principally used in honoring donors.

One of the best-known mosaic floor inscriptions in churches was in Madaba, Jordan, where the oldest known map of Israel and Jordan was set into the floor in the sixth century AD. The place-names of cities, geographical features, and passages of Scripture are given in Greek. Church floors typically contain dated or undated dedications, blessings, and Scripture quotations that appear in Aramaic, Coptic, Syriac, Latin, and Greek. Symbolism often accompanies the inscriptions, but in AD 427 an edict was issued forbidding the use of crosses and other religious symbols on pavements so that they might not be stepped on. It is not clear how widespread this prohibition was.

See also Archaeology and the Bible; Pottery.

Insect

An insect is a small animal without a backbone. Its body has three main parts: a head, a middle section called the thorax, and a lower section called the abdomen. Insects have six legs, arranged in three pairs.

See Ant; Bee; Cricket; Flea; Fly; Gnat; Grasshopper; Locusts; Moth).

Inspiration

See Inspiration of the Bible.

Inspiration of the Bible

"Inspiration of the Bible" is the theological term for how God guided the writers of Scripture so that they communicated his message. Christians believe that the Bible comes from God, even though human authors wrote it in their own languages and styles.

How Did God Communicate with the Writers of Scripture?

The Bible itself tells us that it is an inspired text. It says, "All Scripture is God-breathed" (2 Timothy 3:16). This means every word of the Bible comes from God. The words of the Bible came from God but were written by men. Peter confirmed this when he said that "no prophecy of Scripture comes from one's own interpretation. For no such prophecy was ever brought forth by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit" (2 Peter 1:20–21).

"Men spoke from God." This is the key to understanding how the Bible was written. Thousands of years ago, God chose certain people—such as Moses, David, Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and Daniel—to receive his words and write them down. These writings became the Old Testament. Nearly 2,000 years ago, God chose others—such as Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, and Paul—to share his message of salvation through Jesus Christ. These writings became the New Testament.

God gave his words in many different ways. Some writers of the Old Testament got direct messages from God. Moses received the Ten Commandments carved in stone on Mount Sinai. When David wrote his psalms to God, he predicted events that would occur

Inspiration of the Bible

in Jesus's life. Prophets like Isaiah and Jeremiah were told exactly what to say. So, when they prophesied, it was God's word, not their own. This is why many Old Testament prophets often said, "Thus says the Lord." (This statement appears over 2,000 times in the Old Testament). Other prophets, like Ezekiel and Daniel, received visions and dreams. They wrote down exactly what they saw, even if they did not understand it. Writers like Samuel and Ezra were directed by God to record events in Israel's history.

What Did Jesus Teach about the Old Testament?

Four hundred years after the last book of the Old Testament (Malachi) was written, God's Son, Jesus Christ, came to earth. He taught that the Old Testament writings were authored by God (see Matthew 5:17–19; Luke 16:17; John 10:35). He also pointed to certain passages in the Old Testament as predictions of certain events in his life (see Luke 24:27, 44). The New Testament writers also affirmed that the Old Testament was divinely inspired. It was the apostle Paul who wrote, "All Scripture is God-breathed." Quite specifically, he said this about the Old Testament. Peter said that the Old Testament prophets were motivated by the Holy Spirit to speak from God.

How Were the New Testament Writers Inspired by God?

The New Testament is also God-breathed. Before Jesus returned to God, he told the disciples that he would send the Holy Spirit to remind them of everything Jesus said and guide them to truth (see John 14:26; 15:26; 16:13–15). The Holy Spirit helped the authors of the Gospels remember Jesus' exact words, and the Holy Spirit guided the other authors of the New Testament.

However, inspiration for writing the Gospels didn't only begin when the authors began writing. Inspiration began with the disciples' encounters with Jesus Christ. Their experiences with Jesus changed them and helped them remember everything about him.

John spoke about this at the beginning of his gospel when he declared, "The Word became flesh and made His dwelling among us. We have seen His glory" (John 1:14). This refers to the apostles who lived with Jesus for over three years and saw his glory. In his first letter, John speaks of this experience, saying, "We have seen it and testified to it" (1 John 1:1–2).

The verbs in both the gospel and the letter are in the perfect tense, which refers to a past action with an ongoing effect. John never forgot the encounters he had with Jesus. They lived with him, stayed with him, and he inspired their writing. Matthew, John, and Peter (through Mark) wrote their gospels based on their own experiences. Luke was not an eyewitness but based his gospel on the accounts of eyewitnesses (see Luke 1:1–4).

The inspiration of the rest of the New Testament also came from encounters with the living Christ. Paul claims that his inspiration and call came from his encounter with the risen Christ (see, for example, 1 Corinthians 15:8–10). Peter says the same thing (see 1 Peter 5:1; 2 Peter 1:16–18), as does John (1 John 1:1–4). James and Jude, Jesus' brothers, became believers after they saw the risen Christ (for James, see 1 Corinthians 15:7; for Jude, see Acts 1:14).

So, they also were inspired by their encounters with the living Christ. So, all the writers of the New Testament (with the possible exception of the author of Hebrews, who is unknown) knew the living Christ. This is what made it possible for them to write Scripture. No other authors, no matter how good their writings were, could write Scripture.

The writers of the New Testament letters were inspired by the Holy Spirit. Paul indicated that the New Testament apostles were not writing "in words taught us by human wisdom" but "in words taught by the Spirit" (see 1 Corinthians 2:10–13). What they wrote was Spirit-taught. For example, when John wrote about Jesus giving eternal life, the Holy Spirit helped him express this truth in many different ways, such as:

- "in Him was life" (John 1:4);
- "a fount of water springing up to eternal life" (John 4:14);
- "the bread of life" (John 6:48);
- "the light of life" (John 8:12);
- "the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25); and
- "the way and the truth and the life" (John 14:6).

When Paul wrote about Christ's divine nature, he was inspired by the Holy Spirit to use such phrasing as:

- "in whom [Christ] are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Colossians 2:3);
- "for in Christ all the fullness of the Deity dwells in bodily form" (Colossians 2:9); and
- "the unsearchable riches of Christ" (Ephesians 3:8).

How Did God and People Work Together to Write Scripture?

The writers used their own words and styles to express the meaning given by the Holy Spirit. So, the Scriptures are a result of divine and human cooperation. The Scriptures were not mechanically inspired—God did not exclude the human experience to perfectly communicate the divine word. Rather, the Scriptures

were inspired by God and then written by humans. The Bible, therefore, is both fully divine and fully human.

See also Antilegomena (Disputed Christian Writings).

Instruct, Instructor

The word "instruct" means to teach or give information to someone. An instructor is a person who teaches or gives instructions, similar to a teacher.

See Teacher.

Instruments, Musical

See Musical Instruments.

Intercede, Intercession

The act of praying or making requests to God on behalf of others.

See Prayer.

Intercession of Christ

The theological term for Jesus Christ's work of asking God the Father to save, help, and support people on earth.

The Hebrew word for intercession comes from a root meaning "to meet," which suggests the idea of meeting someone to make a request. This word is used in a prophecy about the "servant of the Lord" in Isaiah: "He bore the sin of many and made intercession for the transgressors (Isaiah 53:12). In Greek, the word for intercession originally meant to "meet," "approach," or "appeal." During the period between the Old and New Testaments, this word was used to describe personally asking an official for a favor (as seen in 2 Maccabees 4:8). In the New Testament, the noun form is translated both as "intercession" (1 Timothy 2:1) and as "prayer" (1 Timothy 4:5).

Theologians see Christ's intercession as the second part of his priestly work. His suffering and death on the cross were the first part. This fixed the problem of human wrongdoing (sin) and made things right between God and people again (1 Timothy 2:5–6). In the Old Testament, priests prayed for the people. On the Day of Atonement, the high priest entered the holy of holies with the sin offering's blood. He then made the place holy with incense and sprinkled blood on the"mercy seat" (Leviticus 16:11–19). After Jesus died for sins, He went to the Father and entered heaven, where he now represents his people (Hebrews 7:25).

Christ's Intercession on Earth

Before beginning his life of intercession in heaven, Jesus Christ prayed and interceded for people on earth. This matched his teaching that his followers should always pray and not become discouraged ("lose heart, Luke 18:1). The Bible often shows Jesus praying. For example, he prayed at the grave of his friend Lazarus (John 11:41–42). He spent all night in prayer on a mountain before choosing the twelve apostles (Luke 6:12–13). After warning his disciple Peter that Satan wanted to test him, Jesus said to Peter, "I have prayed for you that your faith may not fail" (Luke 22:32). Jesus's first words on the cross were a prayer for those who persecuted him (Luke 23:34).

The "high priestly prayer" in John 17 is the most complete example of an intercessory prayer by Jesus in the Bible. This prayer is based on his close relationship with his Father (John 17:5, 8). Jesus prays for three things:

1. Jesus prays for himself, asking that he might glorify the Father and finish the work he was sent to do (John 17:1–5).
2. Jesus prays for his disciples, who were chosen to spread the gospel after he was gone (John 17:8–9).
3. Jesus prays for all believers (John 17:20).

The goals of his intercession include:

1. the unity of God's people (John 17:11, 21),
2. their joy despite hardships and discouragement (John 17:13),
3. their protection from evil (John 17:15),
4. their sanctification (being made holy) by the word of God (John 17:17), and
5. their eternal fellowship with Christ (John 17:24).

Christ's Intercession in Heaven

Christ's intercession for his people, which began on earth, continues in heaven. The Letter to the Hebrews describes Christ as a priest and focuses on his ongoing ministry of intercession. His heavenly intercession follows his earthly sacrifice, which was completed "once for all" (Hebrews 10:10–18). Jesus himself said, "Everyone who acknowledges me before men, I also will acknowledge before my Father who is in heaven" (Matthew 10:32). This ongoing intercession is recognized in New Testament phrases like "through Jesus Christ" (Romans 1:8; 16:27; 1 Peter 2:5), "through him" (Colossians 3:17; Hebrews 13:15), and "in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ" (Ephesians 5:20).

The New Testament explicitly affirms the doctrine of Christ's heavenly intercession in four key passages. The apostle Paul says that Christ is "at the right hand

of God, who indeed intercedes for us" (Romans 8:34). The writer of Hebrews states that Christ "is able for all time to save those who draw near to God through him since he always lives to make intercession for them" (Hebrews 7:25). Further, Christ has entered "into heaven itself, now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf" (Hebrews 9:24). The apostle John also describes this ministry: "If anyone does sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous" (1 John 2:1). The Greek word for "advocate" refers to a legal counselor who represents a client's cause before a judge. John thus presents the risen Lord as appearing before God on behalf of his people, offering his own obedience and suffering as the reason for their forgiveness.

How Does Intercession Work?

Christ's intercession in heaven has two aspects. It is both complete and ongoing. His redemptive work is finished. But, he continues to care for God's people. In this way, Christ's intercession includes the following:

1. His presence is the basis for each believer's justification (being made right with God, Hebrews 9:24).
2. He answers every charge brought against them by Satan (Romans 8:33; Revelation 12:10).
3. Through him, believers have access to God's presence (Hebrews 4:14–16).
4. His ongoing advocacy for believers before the Father as they pray.

In response, God the Father gives believers many spiritual blessings. John Owen, a Puritan who lived from 1616 to 1683, said, "The intercession of Christ ... is his continual appearance for us in the presence of God, representing the power of his sacrifice, along with his tender care, love, and desire for the well-being, support, deliverance, and salvation of the church."

The Bible describes the people for whom Christ intercedes in both broad and narrow terms. Christ is said to pray for all people everywhere (Isaiah 53:12; compare Matthew 26:28). More specifically, He prays for his redeemed community, the church (John 14:16; 17:9, 20; Hebrews 4:15–16). Yet Christ's prayers are also focused on the specific needs of individual believers (Luke 22:31–32; 1 John 2:1).

Interest

A fee charged for borrowing money.

See Debt; Banker, Banking; Money.

Intermediate State

The intermediate state is the state of the human person after death and before the final resurrection. In other words, it is what happens to a person when they die before the resurrection. Such teaching is more developed in the New Testament than in the Old Testament. It is a mistake to think that reference to it is completely missing in the Old Testament (for example, Job 19:25).

What Does the Bible Say About the Intermediate State?

According to Christ in Matthew 22:32, the intermediate state is suggested in such texts as Exodus 3:6. Even in the New Testament, an account of the intermediate state is not given clearly. It is hinted at from teaching about the physical death and resurrection of all people, but mainly of believers. This is taught by Christ himself in Matthew 22:30–32. The apostles, particularly Paul, teach this as in 1 Corinthians 15.

In addition, the Bible teaches that a human being is a unity of soul and body and not simply a soul that happens to be embodied (Genesis 2:7). This provides some information about what happens to a person after death. From such details, two conclusions can be made about the intermediate state.

1. Physical death is not the total end of the life of the individual. The person lives on after this. This is not merely in the memories of those who survive but as a distinct personality. In the case of believers, they are aware of the loving presence of God (Philippians 1:23).
2. Such an existence is not how humans were intended to be. It is incomplete or unusual since having a body is essential for a person to be in God's image. The individual, surviving death, waits for the resurrection of the body. In the case of a Christian, he or she will experience complete redemption, a state of complete freedom from sin in the presence of Christ (1 Corinthians 15:50–58).

The biblical data is less clear about the intermediate state for those who are not Christians. This includes the difficult passage about Christ preaching to the "spirits in prison" in 1 Peter 3:19–20.

What Is the Intermediate State Like?

Scripture is limited in the way it shows what life in the intermediate state is like. In Philippians 1:23, Paul says of himself that after his death he will be "with Christ, which is far better indeed," but he gives no details. It is not wise to look for these details in such biblical incidents as that of Saul and the "medium

at Endor" (1 Samuel 28:7). A medium is a person who communicates with human beings in the spiritual world. This text has many different interpretations.

Christ's parable of the rich man and Lazarus in Luke 16:19–31 is also difficult because of its symbolic character. The purpose of this parable is to teach about the importance of the present life for a person's eternal fate. It must be treated with caution. Perhaps the most that can be said is that the dead in Christ are "immediately with God." They rest in his loving presence until the resurrection. The unsaved are in a comfortless condition awaiting their resurrection to judgment (John 5:29).

The Intermediate State in Christian Thought

Throughout history, Christians have looked at three main ideas to better understand what the Bible teaches about the time between a person's death and the final judgment:

1. Greek philosophers, especially Plato, have influenced how some Christians think about faith. This influence has appeared many times throughout Christian history. Platonic thought separates the physical body, which is evil, from the soul, which is good.

The Bible includes Paul's teaching about the difference between flesh [physical body] and spirit. Some people misunderstood what Paul meant about this. They focused too much on the soul and not enough on the body.

This misunderstanding led to two problems:

1. People paid less attention to the Bible's teaching that God will raise dead people back to life.
2. Some people completely ignored that this raising of the dead will happen at the end of time.

People who follow Plato's ideas believe:

- Physical things are less important than spiritual things
- The soul is more important than the body
- The physical raising of dead bodies is not very important

The belief that the soul lives on without a body after death is sometimes used instead of the idea of a temporary state before the resurrection. However, there is no clear support for this belief in the Bible. In modern theology, there is a tendency to downplay the historical aspects of faith, similar to how people used to downplay the physical body. This often leads to either making life after death seem only spiritual or even denying it altogether.

However, the Bible makes it clear that the intermediate state is a period between two forms of having a body: our current physical bodies and the "spiritual body" (1 Corinthians 15:44). The second phase occurs at Christ's second coming (15:23).

1. During the Reformation, a controversy arose between John Calvin and some of the Anabaptists over "soul sleep." Calvin strongly believed that the intermediate state is one of conscious awareness of God's presence. This is something his opponents denied. For Calvin, such a denial was the same as holding that the soul is destroyed at death. It was the same as denying that Christ exercises rule over the dead before they are resurrected.

Calvin's view is supported by Paul's statement that nothing separates the believer from the love of God. "Nothing" means not even death can separate us from the love of God (Romans 8:35–39).

The biblical teaching that upon death the believer "sleeps" (1 Thessalonians 4:14) is interpreted to mean that the dead no longer communicate with the living on earth and no longer engage in labor, but are in a state of rest. To "fall asleep in Jesus" means to enjoy the presence of Jesus in a state without a body. The closest comparison is like a person dreaming who may be aware but does not depend on the function of any of the senses of the body.

1. Can people change spiritually after they die, or is their spiritual state permanent at death? This question includes three main parts:

- Can people turn away from their sins (repent) after death?
- Can people grow closer to God after death?
- Can people be cleansed from their sins after death?

It is the teaching of the Roman Catholic Church that death is followed by purgatory for all who are imperfect. In purgatory the soul is freed from the remnants of sin. The period of purgation may be lessened by the gifts, prayers, and masses of those who survive the deceased.

Most Protestants reject this idea as disagreeing with the biblical teaching. Three arguments are offered:

1. The work of Christ is complete and finished (Hebrews 9:28).
2. It is impossible for one human being to earn or otherwise gain grace for another (Luke 17:10).
3. The Bible teaches that the eternal state of the soul is determined by its condition at death (Hebrews 9:27).

See also Place of the Dead; Hades; Heaven; Hell; Paradise; Sheol.

Interpreter

A person who helps communicate between speakers of different languages. Or, one who explains dreams.

Joseph pretended to need an interpreter to speak to his brothers (Genesis 42:23). Also, dreams needed to be interpreted (Genesis 40:8; 41:15–16; Daniel 2; 4:6–9, 18–24; 5:7–8, 12–17; 7:16). The interpreter was sometimes one who acted as a mediator (Job 33:23).

Ezra and Nehemiah acted as interpreters or translators of the law of Moses when it was read to the Jews who had returned from exile (Nehemiah 8:8–9). They must not have known Hebrew.

In New Testament times, the interpreter:

- Explained the words of those who spoke in tongues (1 Corinthians 14:28)
- Translated foreign languages (Acts 2:6)
- Explained the Scriptures (Luke 24:27)

Intertestamental Period

The time between the end of the Old Testament and the beginning of the New Testament. This period includes important events in Jewish history that are recorded in the books of 1 and 2 Maccabees.

See Maccabees, 1 and 2.

Iob

Iob is another name for Jashub, a son of Issachar (Genesis 46:13).

See Jashub #1.

Iphdeiah

Iphdeiah was Shashak's son from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:25).

Iphtah

Iphtah was a city in the Shephelah, the low hill country of Judah. It was given to the tribe of Judah for an inheritance. It was listed between Ashan and Ashnah (Joshua 15:43).

Iphtah-el

Iphtah-el was a valley on the border of Asher and Zebulun (Joshua 19:14, 27). It may be the modern Sahl el-Battof.

Ir

Ir was a man from the tribe of Benjamin. He was the father of Shuppim and Huppim (1 Chronicles 7:12). Ir may be identical with Iri in verse 7. In Numbers 24:19, the same Hebrew word is not used as a name. Instead, it is translated as "the city" in the King James Version and the New International Version.

Ira

1. A priest of King David or chief official in his service at the time of the revolt of Sheba (2 Samuel 20:26).
2. A warrior among the mighty men of King David, known as "the thirty" (2 Samuel 23:26). He was the son of Ikkesh of Tekoa (1 Chronicles 11:28; 27:9). He became a commander of the sixth division of the militia of David.
3. A warrior among the mighty men of King David, known as "the thirty." He is an Ithrite (2 Samuel 23:38; 1 Chronicles 11:40).

Irad

A son of Enoch, from the family line of Cain (Genesis 4:18).

Iram

The leader of a tribe (chief) in Edom (Genesis 36:43; 1 Chronicles 1:54).

Iri

Iri was Bela's son from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 7:7).

Irijah

A guard from the tribe of Benjamin who arrested the prophet Jeremiah when he was leaving Jerusalem to inspect property he had the right to buy (Jeremiah 32:6–7). Irijah accused Jeremiah of trying to join the Babylonian army. Because of this false charge, the officials had Jeremiah beaten and put in prison (37:13–14).

Ir-Nahash

Son of Tehinnah, Eshton's son from Judah's tribe (1 Chr 4:12). Some translations note the alternate rendering, "city of Nahash" (mg niv, kjv).

Iron

A strong metal used to make tools and weapons in ancient times.

See Minerals and Metals.

Iron (Place)

Iron is the King James Version form of Yiron, a city in the land of Naphtali (Joshua 19:38).

See Yiron.

Ironsmith

An artisan who normally worked in iron (Is 44:12); a blacksmith. The first worker in iron recorded in the Bible is Tubal-cain (Gn 4:22). In Israel iron became widely known and used about the 11th century BC (Dt 3:11; Jos 6:19, 24; 17:16; Jgs 1:19; 4:3, 13). See Minerals and Metals.

Irpeel

City of inheritance allotted to Benjamin's tribe (Jos 18:27), perhaps situated in the hill country several miles northwest of Jerusalem, near Gibeon.

Irrigation

The practice of bringing water to farmland through human-made systems like channels and ditches.

See Agriculture.

Ir-shemesh

Ir-shemesh was a city assigned to the tribe of Dan (Joshua 19:41). It is probably the same city as Beth-shemesh.

Iru

Iru was Caleb's son from the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 4:15).

Isaac

The son of Abraham and Sarah and the father of Jacob and Esau. Isaac was one of the patriarchs of Israel, the early fathers or founding leaders of the Israelite people in the Bible.

Isaac's Birth and Early Life

The name Isaac has an interesting language origin. It is the English version of the Hebrew Yitshaq, in Greek "Isaak." As an imperfect form, it means "he laughs." As a perfect form, it means "he laughed." Scholars have discussed the meaning of who is doing the laughing in the name.

If God is the "he" who laughs, the name could show divine amusement. Abraham and Sarah both laughed at the prospect of having a child (Genesis 17:17; 18:12). God's promise was fulfilled when they suddenly became parents.

Isaac's family background is also interesting. Sarah was not only the wife of Abraham but also his half-sister (Genesis 20:12). This fact alone may have interfered with conception in their earlier years. Because of this relationship, Isaac belonged to both sides of Terah's family. According to common practice at the time, the son of the legal wife took precedence over the male offspring of concubines. This meant Isaac had priority of inheritance over Ishmael. The gifts that Abraham later gave to the sons of his concubines (25:6) were without prejudice to Isaac's inheritance.

Following God's instructions (Genesis 17:10–14), Abraham circumcised Isaac on the eighth day as a member of the covenant community. The next ceremony came when he was probably around three years old. In eastern countries people celebrate a child's transition from milk to solid food with a feast. This event is still sometimes observed. During the celebration, the mother chews a mouthful of solid food and pushes it into the baby's mouth with her tongue. The infant is often so shocked by this treatment that it promptly expels the food, and the mother repeats the process. For an observer the procedure can be hilarious, and Ishmael may have been laughing at this when Sarah got angry (21:8–10).

During the years of Isaac's youth, Abraham was living in Philistine territory (Genesis 21:34). The test of the father's faith and obedience came in this period. Abraham has watched this son of God's promise grow up into a healthy young man. Then God asks him to offer Isaac as a sacrifice.

Isaac was familiar with sacrificial rituals and helped with the preparations. Isaac was also familiar with the traditions that meant the head of the family had power of life or death over everyone in the family. If he spoke any protest as he lay bound on the sacrificial altar, it is not mentioned in the story.

When Abraham's faith did not waver, God intervened at the crucial moment and provided another offering, a ram. Because of Abraham's obedience, God promised him great blessing. Isaac also participated in this blessing (Genesis 22; 25:11). It was this act of faith and obedience that Paul honored centuries later by calling Abraham the forefather of the Christian church (Romans 4).

Isaac's Marriage and Family

After Sarah's death (Genesis 23), Abraham wanted to secure a bride for Isaac. It was the custom for parents to arrange marriages for their children. He didn't want Isaac to marry a local non-Jewish woman. Instead, Abraham sent his household steward to Nahor in

Mesopotamia to seek a bride for his son from among his relatives.

Genesis 24 describes how the servant met Rebekah. The story emphasizes faith, perseverance, and divine blessing. Nahor officially engaged Rebekah to Isaac even before he had met the rest of her family. Rebekah's father, Bethuel, and brother, Laban, agreed to this arrangement. Rebekah left her home with the family's blessing to take up her new responsibilities in Palestine as Isaac's wife.

When Abraham died at an old age, Isaac and Ishmael buried him in the cave of Machpelah (Genesis 25:8–9). Isaac was now the patriarch of the family and responsible for leading and making important decisions for the whole family group. He pleaded with God that Rebekah might bear children. She bore twin sons, Esau ("the hairy one") and Jacob ("supplanter," which means one who takes another's place).

Esau became a hunter, and Isaac favored him. Jacob was more of a settler and farmer and was favored by his mother. Jacob was also crafty. He took advantage of Esau's extreme hunger one day, bargaining with his older brother to exchange his birthright for some lentil stew. Owning the birthright meant Jacob would get a double inheritance (Deuteronomy 21:17).

Isaac's Later Years and Legacy

When famine came to the land, God told Isaac not to visit Egypt (Genesis 26:2). Isaac stayed in Palestine, where God told him he would enjoy good living. When the men of the area asked about Rebekah, Isaac became fearful and said she was his sister. When the lie was revealed, Abimelech the king rebuked Isaac. The king warned everyone in the area not to interfere with Isaac. Isaac prospered so much that Abimelech finally asked him to move. Isaac took his family to Beersheba, where there was plenty of water for his flocks, and his fortune increased.

Although Esau was Isaac's favorite son, his father did not approve of Esau's two marriages to Hittite women. When Isaac felt that the end of his life was approaching, he wanted to bless his firstborn in the traditional manner (Genesis 27). Rebekah overheard his instructions to Esau. She encouraged Jacob to deceive the blind old man by disguising himself as Esau and taking his brother's blessing.

The deception succeeded, and Isaac gave Jacob the blessing of the firstborn. When Esau appeared to receive his blessing, he was too late. Esau was very bitter against Jacob because of what had happened. Rebekah sent Jacob away to her brother Laban in Mesopotamia, to escape Esau's anger and also to find a wife. Esau did receive a blessing from Isaac, but a lesser one. Two decades later a wealthy Jacob returned with his family. He made peace with Esau before Isaac died, and the brothers buried Isaac in Hebron (Genesis 35:27–29).

Isaac is not as well-known in the Old Testament narratives as Abraham or Jacob. New Testament passages like Acts 7:8, Romans 9:7, Galatians 4:21–31, and Hebrews 11:9–20 recognize his importance for covenantal faith (faith based on trusting in God's promises and following His instructions). Isaac represents the new covenant that God made with Abraham as the child of God's promise.

See also Israel, History of; Patriarchs, Period of the.

Isaiah, Book of

Preview

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Author

The prophet Isaiah, whose name means "the Lord saves," lived and ministered in Jerusalem. Because of his repeated contact with the kings of Judah, some scholars believed that Isaiah was related to the royal family, but this is not certain. According to chapters 7 and 8, Isaiah was married and had at least two sons, Shear-jashub and Maher-shalal-hash-baz, whose symbolic names illustrated God's dealings with the nation as a whole. The "disciples" mentioned in 8:16 probably assisted Isaiah in his ministry and may have helped him record the book that bears his name.

When Isaiah saw the Lord in the famous temple vision described in chapter 6, he was willing to go wherever God sent him, even though he would face strong opposition (6:9–10). King Ahaz proved to be particularly resistant to Isaiah's advice (7:4–17), and the people in general ridiculed his preaching (5:10–12; 28:9–10). During the reign of the godly Hezekiah, however, Isaiah's ministry was much appreciated, and the king consulted him eagerly during times of crisis (37:1–7, 21–35).

Isaiah is usually regarded as the greatest of the writing prophets. Some of the chapters in his book display an unparalleled literary beauty and make use of poetic devices and a rich variety of symbols. Chapters 40–66 contain many powerful passages that underscore the grandeur of the book. It is ironic, then, that many scholars attribute these chapters to a "second" or "third" Isaiah, unknown authors who wrote much later than Isaiah in connection with the Babylonian exile. Yet elsewhere in the OT, the names of all who wrote the prophetic books are preserved, and it would be most unusual for the Jews not to know who wrote such magnificent prophecy as chapters 40–66.

Date

Since many of the events recorded in chapters 1–39 took place during the ministry of Isaiah, most of these chapters were probably written by about 700 BC or shortly thereafter. The destruction of the Assyrian army in 701 BC represents the climax of the first half of the book, fulfilling the prophecy of 10:16, 24–34 and 30:31–33. In 37:38 Isaiah refers to the death of King Sennacherib, which did not occur until 681 BC. This means that some of the earlier chapters, along with 40–66, were probably written later, during Isaiah's retirement years. A gap of several decades could help account for the change in subject matter that is found in the last half of the book. In these chapters Isaiah projects into the future as he addresses the Jews who would be in exile in Babylon about 550 BC.

Background

Isaiah's public ministry occurred primarily from 740–700 BC, a period marked by the rapid expansion of the nation of Assyria. Under King Tiglath-pileser III (745–727 BC), the Assyrians moved to the west and south, and by 738 BC the Assyrian monarch was demanding tribute from Damascus and Israel. About 734 BC Rezin of Damascus (Syria) and Pekah of Israel organized a coalition to rebel against Assyria, and they tried to enlist the support of King Ahaz of Judah. But Ahaz refused to join, and when the kings of Damascus and Israel invaded Judah (see 7:1), Ahaz appealed directly to Tiglath-pileser for help (cf. 2 Kgs 16:7–9). With little hesitation the Assyrians returned to capture Damascus and to turn the northern kingdom of Israel into an Assyrian province.

The puppet king Hoshea ruled over Israel from 732–723 BC but was imprisoned when he joined a revolt against Shalmaneser V, the new Assyrian king. Shalmaneser besieged the capital city of Samaria, which finally fell in 722 BC, spelling the end of the northern kingdom. Sargon succeeded Shalmaneser in 722 and had to quell a number of revolts. In 711 BC Sargon captured the Philistine city of Ashdod in a campaign that became the occasion of Isaiah's prophecy of chapter 20.

Even more important was the widespread rebellion that broke out with the accession of Sennacherib in 705 BC. King Hezekiah of Judah withheld his normal tribute payment, and by 701 BC Sennacherib had invaded Palestine to punish the rebels. The details of this campaign are given in Isaiah 36–37 and tell how city after city was captured by the Assyrians before the invaders stood at the gates of Jerusalem and demanded total surrender. With almost no hope of survival, Hezekiah nevertheless was encouraged by Isaiah to trust God, and in one night the angel of the Lord struck down 185,000 Assyrian soldiers, virtually wiping out Sennacherib's army (Is 37:36–37).

In an effort to befriend the enemies of Assyria, Hezekiah showed his treasures to envoys of the king of Babylon (39:1–4). Isaiah warned that someday the Babylonian armies would conquer Jerusalem and carry off those very treasures, along with the residents of the city (vv 5–7). Not only did Isaiah predict the Babylonian captivity of 586–539 BC (cf. 6:11–12), but he also foretold that Israel would be released from Babylon (48:20). The Chaldean kingdom led by Nebuchadnezzar would be God's instrument of judgment upon Judah, but they too would suffer defeat. One of Isaiah's most remarkable prophecies was the naming of Cyrus, king of Persia, the ruler who would conquer the Babylonians in 539 BC and release Israel from exile (cf. 44:28). Along with the Medes (cf. 13:17), Cyrus won several important victories before sending his troops against Babylon. Isaiah hailed him as one anointed by the Lord to bring deliverance for Israel (45:1–5).

Literary Unity

Largely because of the references to the later kingdoms of Babylon and Persia, the unity of Isaiah has been called into question. Chapters 40–66 move abruptly into the exilic period of 550 BC, almost 150 years after Isaiah lived. Moreover, the Servant of the Lord plays a prominent role in these chapters and the messianic king fades into the background. Brilliant poetic passages are found in chapters 40, 53, 55, and 60, demonstrating remarkable depth and power.

Although these factors are sometimes cited as a sign of disunity, there are actually strong indications for unity in the book. For example, the historical interlude (chs 36–39) forms a hinge or bridge that links chapters 1–35 and 40–66. Chapters 36–37 complete the Assyrian section, and chapters 38–39 introduce the Babylonian material. Most of the linking chapters are written in prose, while the others (in some translations) are

largely poetry. From the standpoint of verbal or stylistic unity, one can point to Isaiah's favorite title for God, "the Holy One of Israel." This title appears 12 times in chapters 1–39, and 14 times in chapters 40–66, but only seven times in the rest of the OT. A study of the famous Servant Songs of 52:13–53:12 reveals several ties with earlier passages, especially in chapters 1–6. The servant who is smitten and wounded (53:4–5) receives the same punishment as the beaten and injured nation of 1:5–6 (also cf. 52:13 with 2:12 and 6:1).

Theological Teaching

Isaiah is to the OT as the book of Romans is to the NT—a book filled with rich theological truth. Like Romans, Isaiah unveils the sinfulness of God's rebellious people and his gracious provision of salvation. Because God is the Holy One of Israel (1:4; 6:3), he cannot ignore sin but must punish those who are guilty. Both Israel (5:30; 42:25) and the other nations (2:11, 17, 20) experience a time of judgment known as the Day of the Lord. In anger God raises his hand against his people (cf. 5:25), but ultimately his wrath is poured out upon Babylon and the nations (cf. 13:3–5; 34:2).

With the fall of Assyria and Babylon, the Day of the Lord becomes a day of joyous victory (10:27; 61:2). According to Isaiah 63:4, it is the year of the Lord's redemption. Earlier, Israel had been redeemed from slavery in Egypt; now the return from the Babylonian captivity brings equal joy (52:9; 61:1). The ultimate redemption is to be accomplished through the death of Christ, and Isaiah 53 describes our Lord's suffering and death in graphic terms. His ministry as the Suffering Servant is also introduced in 49:4 and 50:6–7; meanwhile, 49:6 states that the servant will be "a light for the Gentiles." Looking ahead to the Second Coming, Isaiah predicts a messianic age of peace and righteousness. Nations will "beat their swords into plowshares" (2:4) and the "Prince of Peace" will rule forever (9:6–7).

Throughout the book God is pictured as the all-powerful Creator (48:13)—the sovereign One seated on a throne, high and exalted; the King, the Lord Almighty (6:1, 5). He controls the armies of the earth (13:4) and removes rulers as he wills (40:23–24). Before him, nations "are but a drop in the bucket" (40:15, nlt), and compared with him all idols are worthless and without power (41:29; 44:6). This is the God who shows his fury to his foes and his love to his servants (66:14).

Content

Messages of Judgment and Hope (1–12)

In the opening chapter Isaiah characterizes Israel (including Judah) as "a sinful nation" that has rebelled against God. Although the people regularly bring offerings to him, their worship is hypocritical, an attempt to mask their oppression of the poor and helpless. The Lord encourages the nation to repent of their sin or face the fires of judgment. After this introduction, Isaiah turns to describe the peace of the messianic age in 2:1–4. The day will come when all nations will obey God's word and live at peace. "The mountain of the Lord"—Jerusalem—will be raised up "and all the nations shall flow to it" (2:2–3, rsv). In the meantime, however, both Israel and the nations have exalted themselves against the Lord, and he will judge them in an awesome display of power. For Israel, God's judgment will bring great upheaval, including the loss of its leaders. Defiant and ruthless, the rulers will face either death or deportation. Chapter 3 ends by denouncing the pride and vanity of the women of Zion; they, too, will suffer disgrace. After Jerusalem is cleansed of its sin, the remnant will enjoy the rule of "the branch of the Lord," who will protect and shield his people (4:2–6).

In 5:1–7 Isaiah presents a short song about Israel as God's vineyard. The Lord did everything possible to ensure a yield of good grapes, but the vineyard produced nothing but bad fruit and had to be destroyed. Isaiah then pronounces six woes against Israel, and announces that the Assyrian army will invade the land. Against the backdrop of Israel's sin, Isaiah (ch 6) gives an account of the vision through which he was called as a prophet. Overwhelmed by the holiness of God and by his own sinfulness, Isaiah thought he was ruined, but when he was assured that his sins were forgiven, he responded positively to God's call in spite of the stubbornness of the nation to which he was sent.

One of the most stubborn individuals in all the nation was King Ahaz of Judah, and chapter 7 describes Isaiah's encounter with this godless ruler. When Ahaz was threatened by Damascus and the northern kingdom, he refused to believe Isaiah's promise that God would protect him. This was the occasion on which Isaiah gave Ahaz the sign of Immanuel (7:14). The "virgin" refers ultimately to Mary and "Immanuel" to Christ (Mt 1:23), but in the near fulfillment the child could be Isaiah's own son Maher-shalal-hash-baz (Is 8:3). (See four interpretations of this passage in Virgin Birth of Jesus.) This name (meaning "swift to plunder and quick to spoil," v 1, nlt mg) would be a sign that soon Judah's enemies would fall; "Immanuel" signified that God would be with Judah (v 10, nlt mg). However, if Ahaz appealed for help to the king of Assyria, Isaiah warned him, Assyria's powerful armies would one day invade Judah also (cf. 7:17–25; 8:6–8). The destruction

brought by Assyria would plunge Judah into a time of famine and distress (8:21–22).

Nevertheless, the gloom and darkness associated with the Assyrian invasion would not last indefinitely, and 9:1–5 speaks of a time of peace and joy. Verses 6–7 introduce a child who would become a righteous King and would rule forever. This "Prince of Peace" is the Messiah, the "Mighty God" whose kingdom is described in 2:2–4.

For the immediate future, however, both Israel and Judah will suffer the agony of war as punishment for their sins. God is angry with his people because they are proud and arrogant, and their leaders disregard the pleas of the poor and needy. Civil war and foreign invasion will crush the hapless nation (9:8–10:4). But once Israel has been judged, God will turn his hand against Assyria, the instrument he has used to judge other nations. Because of her string of victories, Assyria is filled with pride and is eager for more triumph. Yet even at the moment when Jerusalem is about to succumb, God will cut down the Assyrian army like a cedar in Lebanon and spare his people (10:26–34).

After Assyria's defeat, Isaiah describes the restoration of Israel and the powerful rule of the Messiah (ch 11). Both Jews and Gentiles will be attracted to Jerusalem to enjoy an era of peace and justice. Like David, the Messiah will have the Spirit of God resting upon him as he judges the wicked and protects the needy. To conclude these opening messages, Isaiah offers two short songs of praise that celebrate God's past deliverance and his promise of future blessing (ch 12).

Oracles against the Nations (13–23)

Although Babylon is not the major power of the day, Isaiah begins his announcements of judgment with two chapters about the destruction of Assyria's neighbor to the south. Babylon will eventually conquer Jerusalem (between 605 and 586 BC), but the Medes (13:17) along with the Elamites will capture Babylon (539 BC). In spite of the glory to be achieved by future kings of Babylon, God will bring their pomp down to the grave (14:9–10). The chapter ends with short prophecies against Assyria and the Philistines.

One of Israel's oldest enemies was the nation of Moab, situated east of the Dead Sea. Even though it was a small country, Isaiah devotes two chapters to these descendants of Lot. Chapter 15 describes the extensive mourning that will overwhelm their cities. After a brief interlude urging the Moabites to submit to Israel and to her God (16:1–5), Isaiah notes that pride will lead to Moab's downfall. Sounds of weeping fill the land as the vines and fields wither and are trampled.

In chapter 17 the fourth oracle is directed against Damascus and Ephraim (the northern kingdom of Israel), probably reflecting their alliance against Judah about 734 BC. Both nations will face ruin, and Ephraim is condemned for abandoning the Lord, her "Savior" and "Rock" (17:10).

In chapters 18 and 19 Isaiah turns to the south and addresses Ethiopia and Egypt, countries that had strong links from 715–633 BC, when an Ethiopian named Shabako became pharaoh in Egypt. But Egypt is plagued with disunity and suffers greatly at the hands of Assyrian kings. In spite of the supposed wisdom of her leaders, Egypt faces economic and political ruin (19:5–15). Yet the time is coming when the Egyptians will be restored and will worship the God of Israel. Along with Assyria and Israel, Egypt will become a blessing (19:24). Some interpreters think this is a prophecy of the salvation of Gentiles during the church age, but others relate this day to the peace of the millennial age (cf. 2:2–4; 11:6–9). For the immediate future, however, Isaiah announces that Assyria will take many Egyptians and Ethiopians into captivity (ch 20).

A second oracle about Babylon (cf. 13:1–14:23) is contained in chapter 21, and Isaiah is staggered as he considers the impact of Babylon's fall (21:3–4). When Babylon collapses, the world will know that her gods were powerless (21:9; cf. Rv 14:8; 18:2).

Although it seems out of place among these oracles against the nations, chapter 22 condemns the city of Jerusalem. Like the nations, Jerusalem is full of revelry (22:2) but will soon experience the terrors of a siege. Since the people no longer rely on the Lord (v 11), he will hand them over to the enemy. Jerusalem's unfaithfulness is exemplified by Shebna, a high official guilty of pride and materialism whose position will be taken by the godly Eliakim (vv 15–23).

The last oracle (ch 23) is directed against the city of Tyre, which resisted capture until Alexander the Great conquered the island fortress in 332 BC. When Tyre fell, the economy of the entire Mediterranean world was shaken, for her ships had carried the goods of the nations far and wide.

Final Judgment and Blessing (24–27)

This section functions as a grand finale to chapters 13–23 in that it anticipates God's judgment upon the nations and the inauguration of the kingdom of God. A defiled earth must bear its punishment (24:5–6) and even the forces of Satan face judgment (vv 21–22).

In chapter 25 Isaiah rejoices over God's great triumph and looks ahead to a day when death will be swallowed up and tears will be wiped from all faces (25:8). Israel's longtime enemies, symbolized by Moab, will be laid low (vv 10–12), but Jerusalem will be a stronghold for the righteous (26:1–3). In 26:7–19 the nation prays that these promises will become a reality. Verses 20–21 indicate that the Lord will indeed respond, pouring out his wrath upon a sin-cursed earth and upon Satan himself (27:1). When that takes place, Israel will be a fruitful vineyard, a blessing to the whole world (27:2–6; contrast 5:1–7). First, however, Israel will have to endure war and exile, and then the remnant will return to Jerusalem.

A Series of Woes (28–33)

Returning to his own historical period, Isaiah pronounces a series of woes upon both the northern and southern kingdoms, as well as one upon Assyria (ch 33). Chapter 28 begins with a description of the fading power of Samaria, the capital of the northern kingdom. Verses 7–10 portray the leaders of Judah in the same light; they have disregarded Isaiah's message and are out of touch with God. Judgment is on the way, and their false preparation (vv 15, 18) will be of no avail. God will fight against Israel (vv 21–22), and even Jerusalem will be put under siege until God in his mercy intervenes (29:1–8). Because of their hypocritical worship, the people deserve to be punished, but in the future Israel will again acknowledge the Lord and be made physically and spiritually whole (29:17–24).

Chapters 30 and 31 denounce Judah's proposed alliance with Egypt in the effort to thwart Assyria. God wants his people to trust him, not their unreliable neighbors to the south. The Lord promises to protect Jerusalem (30:18; 31:5) and defeat the invading Assyrian army (30:31–33; 31:8–9). None can stand before his mighty sword.

Continuing on this positive note, Isaiah goes on to emphasize the righteous rule of the messianic king in chapters 32 and 33. Zion will enjoy peace and security at last (32:2, 17–18; 33:6), a great change from Isaiah's own time. In eighth-century BC Judah the women might feel secure (32:9), but the Assyrian troops will devastate the crops and precipitate widespread mourning. However, the lamenting will soon end, as the prophet pronounces woe upon Assyria in 33:1. After Isaiah prays for the destruction of Assyria (33:2–9), God promises to take action (vv 10–12). Gone will be the enemy soldiers and officials, for the Lord will save his people and bring them justice and security.

More Judgment and Blessing (34–35)

This section forms a climax to chapters 28–33. Once more, cataclysmic judgment precedes a time of blessing and restoration. In chapter 34 Isaiah depicts a judgment of cosmic dimensions as he moves to a consideration of the last days. Heaven and earth endure the wrath of God that is poured out upon the nations, and verse 4 provides the basis for John's description of the great tribulation in Revelation 6:13–14. Edom (like Moab; see Is 25:10–12) represents a world judged by the sword of the Lord in his day of vengeance.

Chapter 35, on the other hand, speaks of joy and restoration in a passage that pulsates with life. A blooming desert corresponds to the physical and spiritual age when God will come to redeem his people. Both the return of the Israelites from the Babylonian captivity and the second coming of Christ fit this glorious scene.

Historical Interlude (36–39)

These chapters form the hinge that connects the two halves of the book. Chapters 36 and 37 contain the fulfillment of Isaiah's prophecies about Assyria's collapse, and chapters 38 and 39 introduce the Babylonian captivity that forms the backdrop for chapters 40–66. In 701 BC King Sennacherib of Assyria demands the unconditional surrender of Jerusalem. He sends his field commander to address the people and try to gain their submission. With persuasive words, the commander tries to convince the city that surrender is the best policy. Amazingly the people do not panic, and King Hezekiah asks Isaiah to pray for the beleaguered city. The prophet does so and announces that the proud Assyrians will not triumph. Instead, they suffer a terrible disaster as the angel of the Lord strikes down 185,000 men.

Chapters 38 and 39 relate another crisis in Hezekiah's life when he becomes desperately ill. Miraculously, God heals him, and Hezekiah praises the Lord for his gracious intervention. When the king of Babylon sends envoys to congratulate Hezekiah on his recovery, Hezekiah foolishly shows these messengers his royal treasures. Isaiah solemnly announces that someday the armies of Babylon will capture Jerusalem, plunder the land, and take away these treasures.

The Return from Babylon (40–48)

The Babylonian captivity eventually comes, but Isaiah promises that it will end. God, the incomparably powerful Creator, is far greater than any king, nation, or god, and he will bring his people back to Jerusalem. To accomplish this return from exile, God raises up Cyrus, the king of Persia (41:2, 25). The Lord does not forget

his people, and he encourages them to take heart and to rejoice.

In chapter 42 we are introduced to a person even more significant than Cyrus the Persian. Verses 1–7 (the first of four Servant Songs) describe the servant of the Lord, who will bring justice to the nations and will be "a light for the Gentiles" (42:6). This is the Messiah, and the redemption he will accomplish on Calvary (cf. ch 53) is greater than the release from Babylon. In light of the good news associated with the servant, Isaiah praises the Lord for punishing the wicked and rescuing his wayward people. Chapter 43 declares that nothing will stand in the way of Israel's return, and the Lord will remember their sins no more. In fact, he will pour out his Spirit on their descendants (44:3).

A God so great is far more powerful than any idol. In 44:6–20 Isaiah makes use of satire to show the worthlessness of man-made images. God alone has the power to create and to restore, and he will bring Cyrus on the scene to effect the release of the exiles and to begin the rebuilding of Jerusalem. Chapters 46 and 47 contrast the God of Israel and the idols of Babylon. When God raises up Cyrus, Babylon's idols will be unable to save their nation, and the queen of kingdoms (47:5) will collapse along with her sorcerers and astrologers. The final chapter in this section (ch 48) restates God's purpose of gaining release of the Israelites from Babylon through his chosen ally, Cyrus of Persia.

Salvation through the Servant of the Lord (49–57)

Chapters 49–53 contain the final three Servant Songs (cf. also 42:1–7), culminating in the death of the servant for the sins of the world (52:13–53:12). In the second Servant Song (49:1–7), Isaiah describes the call and ministry of the servant, noting that he will face strong opposition as he accomplishes salvation for Israel and the nations. The rest of chapter 49 deals primarily with the way God will bring Israel back from exile. Soon the land will be filled with a mighty throng (vv 19–21), and the Gentiles will acknowledge Israel and her God (vv 22–23).

Although Israel has fully deserved the exile because of her sins (50:1–3), the suffering endured by the servant (vv 4–11; the third Servant Song) is wholly undeserved. The beating and mocking of verse 6 are prophetic of Christ's experience (cf. Mt 27:26, 30; Mk 15:19). In verses 10–11 of Isaiah 50 the whole nation is challenged to trust in the Lord, as the servant did. There is, in fact, a believing remnant who obey the Lord (51:1–8), and the Lord promises that he will restore them to their homeland. Israel has drunk the cup of God's wrath (vv 17, 22), but the good news of release from exile causes even the ruins of Jerusalem to burst into songs of joy (52:7–10).

Yet the best news of all is salvation from sin; the final Servant Song (52:13–53:12) tells how Christ wins freedom for those held in bondage to sin. In this brief passage we learn how Christ suffers rejection (53:3) and even disfigurement (52:14). Led like a lamb to the slaughter (53:7), he carries our sins in his body as he dies in ignominy. The people think he is suffering for his own sins (v 4), but he is "pierced" and "crushed for our iniquities" (v 5). The first and last paragraphs of this section (52:13–15; 53:10–12) state that through his suffering the servant is highly exalted. What seems like a terrible defeat is actually victory over death and Satan and brings salvation for many.

As a direct result of the servant's death, great joy comes to all people. In chapter 54 this joy is reflected in Jerusalem's new status as the Lord's wife. Her descendants will be numerous and eager to learn from the Lord. For the first time the plural "servants of the Lord" appears (54:17), apparently including all believers, whether Jew or Gentile (cf. 65:8–9, 13–15). Joy and prosperity also characterize chapter 55, an invitation to a great spiritual banquet. All people are urged to turn to the Lord who keeps his promises to Israel. In 56:1–8, foreigners are invited to come to God's "holy mountain" in Jerusalem, for the temple will be a house of prayer for all the nations (56:7; cf. Mt 21:13).

Believing Gentiles are contrasted sharply with unbelieving Jews, and in 56:9–57:13 Isaiah returns again to the theme of judgment. Israel suffers because her leaders are wicked and because the people are guilty of idolatry. Spiritual healing is available, but unless individuals repent, they cannot be part of the remnant who will return from exile and enjoy peace in the Promised Land.

Ultimate Blessing and Final Judgment (58–66)

The last nine chapters of Isaiah emphasize redemption and glory, but the reality of judgment is also very much in evidence. In fact, chapters 58 and 59 bemoan the sins of Israel. The people are hypocritical in their worship; they are selfish and fail to keep the Sabbath. Lying, oppression, and murder separate the people from God. When Isaiah openly confesses these sins (59:12–13), the Lord suddenly takes action on behalf of his people. Like a mighty warrior, he rescues the believing remnant from Babylon and brings them back to Jerusalem.

In chapter 60 the glory and wealth of Jerusalem reach new heights. Both the city and the sanctuary are adorned with splendor, matching the prosper-

ity of Solomon's reign. Just as the nations treated Solomon with honor, so earth's leaders will assist and strengthen the returning exiles. While it is true that the Persian government did help the Jews repeatedly, the conditions described here will have their ultimate fulfillment during the Millennium and in connection with the new Jerusalem (cf. Rv 21:23; 22:5). The ancient ruins will be rebuilt (Is 61:4), and the Lord will fulfill the covenant made with Abraham and David (Is 61:8; cf. Gn 12:1–3; Is 55:3). Jerusalem will be the city of the holy people, the redeemed of the Lord (Is 62:12), and the Lord will take delight in her (v 4).

In order to accomplish salvation for his people, God will have to judge the ungodly first. The great trampling of the winepress (63:2–3) graphically portrays the judgment process and is linked with the Day of the Lord (cf. 13:3; 34:2). Since God has promised to intervene on behalf of his people, Isaiah prays for the realization of that promise (63:7–64:12). He recalls God's faithfulness in the past and pleads that he will again have mercy upon his suffering people.

The answer to Isaiah's prayer is found in chapter 65. God does promise to give the Holy Land back to his servants, to those who worship him and obey him. But for that segment of the nation that continues in its obstinacy, God promises anguish and destruction. The ultimate joy of God's servants is contained in a description of new heavens and a new earth (65:17–25). Peace, long life, and prosperity will be among the blessings enjoyed in an era that seems to combine features of the Millennium and the eternal state (cf. ch 60).

In a fitting summary, chapter 66 ties together the themes of salvation and judgment. God will comfort Jerusalem and abundantly bless her, but sinners are the objects of his wrath. Those who honor him will endure forever, but those who rebel will suffer everlasting rejection.

See also Isaiah (Person); Israel, History of; Messiah; Prophecy; Prophet, Prophetess; Servant of the Lord; Virgin Birth of Jesus.

Isaiah (Person)

Isaiah was a prophet who lived in the eighth century BC, during the reigns of the kings of Judah:

- Uzziah,
- Jotham,
- Ahaz, and
- Hezekiah.

The prophet Isaiah is traditionally recognized as the author of the biblical book of Isaiah.

He was the son of Amoz (Isaiah 1:1) and may have been related to King Amaziah. He grew up in Jerusalem and likely received a good education. He understood people well and became an important political and religious adviser to the nation.

Isaiah had direct access to the kings of Judah. He also appears to have served as a royal historian, recording events during the reigns of several kings (2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:32).

Isaiah's wife is called a prophetess (Isaiah 8:3). They had at least two sons, Shear-jashub (7:3) and Maher-shalal-hash-baz (8:3).

Isaiah's Ministry

Isaiah usually wore clothing associated with prophets, including sandals and a garment made of goat's hair or sackcloth, a rough, coarse fabric. At one point during his ministry, the Lord commanded him to go barefoot and without his usual outer clothing for three years, possibly wearing only a loincloth (Isaiah 20:2–6). This would have been humiliating in a society where clothing was an important sign of a person's social position.

Isaiah worked to correct problems in society and government. He spoke against wrongdoing, even among the most powerful people. He condemned those who claimed to predict the future and criticized wealthy and influential people who failed to use their positions responsibly.

Isaiah urged the people to obey God rather than ignore his covenant (the binding agreement between God and his people). He also rebuked kings for acting according to their own wishes and failing to care for others.

Isaiah's writings show his deep respect for God's greatness and holiness. He spoke against the worship of false gods among the Canaanites. He also criticized his own people for taking part in religious ceremonies without sincere faith in God (Isaiah 1:10–17; 29:13).

Isaiah warned the people of Judah that God would judge them for worshiping false gods. He declared that only a small group of people who remained faithful to God would survive (6:13).

Isaiah foretold the coming of the Messiah, God's promised Savior and King. He described the Messiah as a ruler who would bring peace and reign over God's kingdom (Isaiah 11:1–11; compare 9:6–7). He also described the Messiah as a servant who would obey God and suffer (53:3–12).

Isaiah was one of the most gifted prophets in his use of language. His writings contain many powerful and memorable images and figures of speech that help us understand his message.

Isaiah was a prophet during the final 30 years of the northern kingdom of Israel. Because he lived in Jerusalem, in the southern kingdom of Judah, he spoke less often about Israel. When Israel fell to Assyria, Judah became more vulnerable to an Assyrian attack.

Isaiah urged King Ahaz of Judah to avoid alliances with foreign nations and trust God to protect his people. But Ahaz ignored Isaiah's advice and made an alliance with Assyria.

Hezekiah, the faithful son of Ahaz, tried to free Judah from this dangerous situation. When the Assyrian army, led by King Sennacherib, approached Jerusalem, Isaiah encouraged Hezekiah and the people of Judah to trust the Lord to protect the city. According to Isaiah 37:36–38, the angel of the Lord destroyed much of the Assyrian army. This gave Hezekiah and the people of Judah a short period of peace.

Isaiah is widely regarded as one of the greatest Hebrew prophets. He was highly respected in both Old Testament and New Testament times. One sign of his importance is the collection of writings associated with his name that were not included in the Bible. These are known as apocryphal writings.

See also Book of Isaiah; History of Israel; Prophecy; Prophet, Prophetess.

Iscah

Haran's daughter and Milcah's sister (Genesis 11:29).

Iscariot

Iscariot refers to Judas Iscariot, one of the twelve disciples of Jesus. He is known for betraying Jesus.

See Judas #1.

Ishbah

Ishbah was Mered's son by Bithiah, the daughter of the pharaoh (1 Chronicles 4:17).

Ishbak

One of the sons of Abraham by Keturah (Genesis 25:2; 1 Chronicles 1:32).

Ishbi-benob

A giant who almost killed David. During one of his many battles with the Philistines, David grew faint and Ishbi-benob almost killed him. Abishai killed the giant and saved David (2 Samuel 21:16).

Ishbosheth

Another name for Eshbaal, son of King Saul. He became king after his father died (2 Samuel 2–4). Ishbosheth ruled for a short time before his death.

See Eshbaal.

Ishhod

Ishhod was Hammolecheth's son from the tribe of Manasseh (1 Chronicles 7:18).

Ishi

1. Appaim's son, the father of Sheshan and a descendant of Judah through Jerahmeel's line (1 Chr 2:31).
2. Man from Judah's tribe whose descendants were Zoheth and Ben-zoheth (1 Chr 4:20).
3. Simeonite whose four sons led 500 men to Mt Seir, where they destroyed the remnant Amalekites and settled their own people (1 Chr 4:42).
4. One of the leaders of the half-tribe of Manasseh east of the Jordan (1 Chr 5:24).
5. Name of God, meaning "my husband," by which Israel will one day address him (Hos 2:16).

See also God, Names of.

Ishiah

Ishiah is the King James Version spelling of Isshiah, Izrahiah's son, in 1 Chronicles 7:3.

See Isshiah #1.

Ishijah

Ishijah was Harim's son, who obeyed Ezra's command to divorce his non-Jewish wife (Ezra 10:31).

Ishma

Ishma was Etam's son from the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 4:3).

Ishmael

1. Abraham's first son, born of Hagar. Hagar was the Egyptian servant of Sarah (Abraham's wife). Sarah chose Hagar to have a child with Abraham.

God promised to make a great nation of Abraham, who did not have any children (Genesis 12:2). God promised him that his son would be his heir (15:4). But when Sarah was past 75 years old and had still not had any children, she followed a custom of that time and gave her servant Hagar to Abraham as a concubine. This was meant to give Sarah a child through Hagar (16:1–2). After Hagar became pregnant, she began to treat Sarah with disrespect. Sarah then treated Hagar harshly, causing her to run away. An angel found Hagar and told her to return. The angel also promised her a son, telling her to name him Ishmael, which means "God hears" (16:9–11). The boy was born near Hebron when Abraham was 86 years old (13:18; 16:16).

Abraham and Sarah first thought Ishmael was the son God had promised them (17:17; 18:12). When God later announced that Sarah would have her own son named Isaac, Abraham even asked God to accept Ishmael instead (17:18). When Ishmael was 13, he was circumcised as a witness of God's covenant with Abraham (17:9–14, 22–27). The Lord promised to make Ishmael the father of 12 princes, from which would come a great nation. But the covenant (God's special agreement with Abraham) was to be established with Isaac (17:20–21).

Problems began when Isaac was weaned at about three years of age. When Sarah saw Ishmael mocking her son Isaac, she decided that the son of a slave woman should not be heir with her son Isaac. She demanded that Ishmael and Hagar be sent away. Though this upset Abraham, God told him to do what Sarah asked. Abraham gave them some food and water and sent them away. It was then clear to Abraham that Isaac, not Ishmael, was the son of God's promise.

Hagar survived in the wilderness with the help of an angel. Ishmael became a hunter of wild animals and settled in the wilderness of Paran. He married an Egyptian woman (21:20–21). There is not much more written about him, except that years later he helped bury Abraham (25:9–10). He also gave his daughter Mahalath in marriage (28:9). Ishmael died at the age of 137 (25:17). The names of his 12 sons and their settlements are recorded in Genesis 25:13–16. In later history, a caravan of Ishmaelite traders (also called Midianites, compare Judges 8:22–24) bought Joseph from his brothers and sold him in Egypt (Genesis 37:25–28; 39:1).

Although Isaac received God's special promises instead of Ishmael, this did not mean God rejected Ishmael. Abraham and Sarah first thought too highly of Ishmael's place in God's plan, but later they wrongly tried to exclude him completely.

In the New Testament, Paul uses the story of Ishmael and Hagar to teach the Galatians that the law should not be seen as a burden (Galatians 4:22). He says that those who trust the law of Moses, instead of trusting in God's promises, do not inherit the kingdom of God. Ishmael, the son of the slave woman (here a symbol of the law), did not receive inheritance with the son of the free woman (verse 30).

1. A member of the royal family of King Zedekiah, through his father Nethaniah and grandfather Elishama (2 Kings 25:25). This story takes place during the time when Babylon controlled Judah. The Babylonian king Nebuchadnezzar had put a man named Gedaliah in charge as governor in the city of Mizpah.

Baalis, the king of the Ammonites, convinced Ishmael to kill Gedaliah. Before this happened, a man named Johanan warned Gedaliah about the plot to kill him. Johanan even asked permission to kill Ishmael first to protect Gedaliah, but Gedaliah refused to believe the warning (Jeremiah 40:14–16).

Ishmael came to Mizpah with ten men. While they were eating a meal with Gedaliah, they killed him and the Babylonian soldiers who were with him. The next day, a group of 80 religious pilgrims was traveling from the north to worship at the temple in Jerusalem. Ishmael invited them into Mizpah and then killed 70 of them. He let ten of them live because they offered to give him their hidden food supplies. Ishmael hid all the dead bodies in a large cistern (underground water storage).

After this, Ishmael took everyone else in Mizpah as prisoners, including the prophet Jeremiah and some women from the royal family. He started taking them toward the land of the Ammonites. However, Johanan gathered some soldiers and caught up with Ishmael at a place called Gibeon. Johanan rescued all the prisoners, but Ishmael and his men escaped to Ammonite territory (Jeremiah 41).

1. The son of Azel, a Benjamite of the family of Saul (1 Chronicles 8:38; 9:44).
2. The father of Zebadiah, the governor of the house of Judah under Jehoshaphat (2 Chronicles 19:11).
3. The son of Jehohanan. He was one of the commanders who allied with Jehoiada the priest to make Joash king (while he was still a child) and end the reign of Athaliah (2 Chronicles 23:1).
4. The son of Pashhur, and one of the priests who divorced his foreign wives during Ezra's reforms (Ezra 10:22).

Ishmaelite

Any descendant of Ishmael. Ishmael was the son of the patriarch Abraham by Hagar.

See Ishmael #1.

Ishmaiah

1. Warrior from Benjamin's tribe who joined David at Ziklag in his struggle against King Saul. Ishmaiah was one of David's ambidextrous archers and slingers (1 Chr 12:4).
2. Obadiah's son, a chief officer in Zebulun's tribe in David's time (1 Chr 27:19).

Ishmeelite

The King James Version spelling for "Ishmaelite" (Genesis 37:25–28; 39:1).

See Ishmaelite.

Ishmerai

Ishmerai was Elpaal's son and a chief in the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:18).

Ishod

Ishod is the King James Version spelling of Ishhod, Hammoleketh's son (1 Chronicles 7:18).

See Ishhod.

Ishpah

Ishpah was Beriah's son from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:16).

Ishpan

Ishpan was Shashak's son and a leader in the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:22).

Ishtar

A fertility goddess (a female deity believed to help plants grow and animals reproduce) worshiped in ancient Babylon. The Babylonians wrote stories about her, including the famous Gilgamesh Epic (an ancient poem that tells the adventures of a legendary king named Gilgamesh).

See Gilgamesh Epic.

Ishtob

The King James Version translation for "men of Tob" in 2 Samuel 10:6–8.

See Tob.

Ishuah

The King James Version spelling of "Ishvah," who was a son of the patriarch Asher (Genesis 46:17).

See Ishvah.

Ishuai

Ishuai is the King James Version spelling of Ishvi, Asher's son, in 1 Chronicles 7:30.

See Ishvi #1.

Ishui

Ishui is the King James Version spelling of Ishvi, Saul's son, in 1 Samuel 14:49.

See Ishvi #2.

Ishvah

A son of the patriarch Asher (Genesis 46:17; 1 Chronicles 7:30).

Ishvi

1. The third son of Asher (Genesis 46:17; 1 Chronicles 7:30). He was the founder of the Ishvite clan (Numbers 26:44).
2. A variant form of the name "Ishbosheth." He was one of the sons of King Saul (1 Samuel 14:49).

Ishvite

Any descendant of Ishvi, son of Asher (Numbers 26:44).

See Ishvi #1.

Isis

An important goddess in ancient Egyptian religion and the wife of Osiris (the god of the dead and the afterlife).

See Egypt, Egyptian (Religion).

Ismaiah

Ismaiah is the King James Version spelling of Ishmaiah, a warrior from the tribe of Benjamin who joined David at Ziklag in 1 Chronicles 12:4.

See Ishmaiah #1.

Ismakiah

Ismakiah was a Levite who supervised the items dedicated to God at the temple during King Hezekiah's religious reforms (2 Chronicles 31:13).

Ispah

Ispah is the King James Version spelling of Ishpah, Beriah's son, in 1 Chronicles 8:16.

See Ishpah.

Israel (Person)

Name meaning "one who struggles with God" or "God struggles" (Gn 32:28, nlt mg). It was given to Isaac's son Jacob and to his descendants (35:9–12; cf. Dt 6:1–4). See Jacob #1; Israel, History of.

Israel (Place)

Israel is the name of the land connected with the people of Israel in the Bible. The name may refer to the whole land where the Israelites lived. In some passages, it may refer more specifically to the northern kingdom of Israel.

The borders and political divisions of the land changed during different periods of biblical history.

See Palestine; Canaan, Canaanite.

Israelite

A descendant of the 12 sons of Israel.

"Israel" is the name God gave to Jacob (Genesis 32:28). The Israelites were different from two other family groups that came from Abraham. One group was the Ishmaelites, who came from Abraham's servant Hagar and her son Ishmael. The other group was the Edomites, who came from Jacob's brother Esau. The Israelites lived in Egypt from the time of Joseph until the exodus. Then God led them into Canaan to fulfill his promise to Abraham (17:8).

God led the Israelites out of Egypt through the wilderness. Then he led them into the land of Canaan as he had promised them. Judges, kings, and conquerors from other countries ruled them. In 722 BC, Assyria conquered the northern kingdom. Then Israel became part of that empire.

After this time, "Israel" refers to members of the southern tribes, Judah and Benjamin. An "Israelite" was one who belonged to the remnant of the covenant nation of Israel. This was true both in a religious and political sense.

See also Israel, History of; Jew; Judaism.

Issachar (Person)

1. Jacob's ninth son, the fifth by his wife Leah (Gn 30:17–18); his name perhaps means "reward." Jacob, in his final message to his 12 sons says, "Issachar is a strong donkey, lying down between the sheepfolds" (49:14, nasb); the picture suggested is a loaded donkey who refuses to move his burden, a lazy man who is unwilling to do his share of the work. Little is known about Issachar except what he did along with the other sons of Israel. He had four sons (46:13), who headed clans in the tribe (1 Chr 7:1–5). His family went with Jacob to Egypt, where they died (although Issachar's remains were subsequently moved to Shechem with the other 12 patriarchs—Acts 7:16).

The descendants of Issachar numbered 54,400 at the first census (Nm 1:29), increased to 64,300 at the second (26:25), and to 87,000 during David's reign (1 Chr 7:5). Issachar was the main tribe involved in the fighting led by Deborah, herself a member of the tribe (Jgs 5:15). During the time of David, there were men of the tribe of Issachar who had understanding of what Israel ought to do in warfare (1 Chr 12:32). These men supported David as king to replace Saul.

Issachar was assigned the fourth lot of land after the ark was taken to Shiloh (Jos 19:17). This included the cities of Jezreel, Shunem, and En-gannim, and it lay between the mountains of Gilboa and Tabor. Their allotment was bordered on the south and west by the tribe of Manasseh, on the north by Zebulun and Naphtali, and on the east by the river Jordan. This territory was largely a fertile plain and was often threatened by the Canaanites nearby as well as by foreign invaders.

2. Obed-edom's son, who was a Levite gatekeeper during David's reign (1 Chr 26:5).

Issachar, Tribe of

The Israelite tribe descended from Jacob's son, Issachar. Their land is defined in Joshua 19:17–23, though not in great detail.

The Territory of the Tribe of Issachar

Its eastern border ends at the Jordan. The area can be located through the towns listed in their land, namely:

- Jezreel
- Chesulloth
- Shunem
- Anaharath
- Kishion
- Remeth
- En-gannim

We are more certain about the locations of some of these cities than others.

- Jezreel and En-gannim are in the southeast corner of the valley of Jezreel.
- Chesulloth is just west of Mount Tabor.
- Shunem is at the foot of the hill of Moreh.

The northern border can be identified through the southern boundaries of Zebulun and Naphtali (Joshua

19:10–12, 33–34). The three tribes of Issachar, Naphtali, and Zebulun, all met at Mount Tabor.

On the southern border, some major towns were not conquered in Joshua's time (Judges 1:27), and were taken from Issachar and given to Manasseh (Joshua 17:11):

- Beth-shan
- Ibleam
- Tanaach

Conflicts among the local tribes occurred in this area (as recorded on a stele of Seti I at Beth-shan). The area is called "Mount Yarunta," after Yarmuth (Joshua 21:29). Issachar was located on the rich plateau stretching east of Mount Tabor and the hill of Moreh and north of the Beth-shan Valley.

See also Issachar (Person) #1.

Isshiah

1. Izrahiah's son from Issachar's tribe (1 Chr 7:3).
2. Warrior from Benjamin's tribe who joined David in his struggle against King Saul. Isshiah was one of David's ambidextrous archers and slingers (1 Chr 12:6).
3. Uzziel's son from Levi's tribe (1 Chr 23:20; 24:25).
4. Rehabiah's son from Levi's tribe and a descendant of Moses (1 Chr 24:21).

Isshijah

Isshijah is another spelling of Ishijah, Harim's son in Ezra 10:31.

See Ishijah.

Issue of Blood

The King James Version translation of "suffered from bleeding" or "hemorrhage" in Matthew 9:20 and Mark 5:25. See Hemorrhage.

Isuah

Isuah is the King James Version spelling of Ishvah, Asher's son, in 1 Chronicles 7:30.

See Ishvah.

Isui

Isui is the King James Version form of Ishvi, a son of Asher (Genesis 46:17).

See Ishvi #1.

Italian Regiment, Italian Band, Italian Cohort

The Italian Regiment was a Roman military unit. Some Bible versions call it the "Italian Cohort" or "Italian Band." This was the unit that Cornelius the centurion belonged to. The Italian Regiment is appears once in the Bible (Acts 10:1). The New American Standard Bible reads, "cohort." The King James Versions has, " band."

The Roman army had extra military units called auxiliary regiments. These groups were usually made up of men from different parts of the empire. Jewish men were usually not required to serve in these units. Some regiments had special names, like "Italian" or "Augustan" (which means they served the emperor) (Acts 27:1). It seems that most of the Italian Regiment was made up of Roman citizens who had been born in Rome. Each regiment had six smaller units called centuries. Each century had about 100 men and was led by a centurion. Cornelius was the centurion of one of these centuries. Ten regiments together made up a legion, which had about 6,000 men.

Inscriptions show that an Italian Regiment was in Syria between AD 69 and 157. It may have been there earlier, but we do not have military records from that time.

Italy

Italy is a boot-shaped peninsula located between the Tyrrhenian and the Adriatic seas. Uplands and two major mountain ranges occupy about three-quarters of the land. This includes the Alps, which form a northern boundary, and the Apennines, which form the backbone of the peninsula. The Po River valley comprises the plains and covers the remaining quarter of the land.

Italy in Ancient History

The earliest evidence of human life in Italy comes from ancient stone tools and other objects found at archaeological sites, including sites near Rome. These discoveries show that early humans, including Neanderthals, lived in the region long before recorded history. Farming began to spread through Italy around 6000 BC, allowing communities to grow. By 3000 BC, farming settlements had developed in southern Italy along the Mediterranean coast and in northern Italy near the Po River.

During the following centuries, communities in central Italy continued to develop farming, raising animals, and working with bronze. They also had contact with other cultures around the Mediterranean Sea, including the civilizations of the Aegean region.

During the second millennium BC, an invasion of Indo-European tribes reshaped the culture of the peninsula. They called each area by the name of the tribe that lived there. Among the most important of these tribes were the Latins. They settled in the valley of the Tiber River. This area became known as Latium.

According to the Greek historian Antiochus of Syracuse, who lived in the fifth century BC, a king named Italos once ruled part of southwestern Italy. Tradition places his rule around 1300 BC, although historians cannot confirm this date. The region was said to have been named after him. Over time, the name "Italy" came to refer to more of the peninsula. By the time of Emperor Augustus, who ruled from 27 BC to AD 14, the name was used for the entire peninsula.

By the late eighth century BC, the Etruscans had become an important people in central Italy. Their origins remain uncertain, although some ancient writers believed they came from Asia Minor (modern Turkey). The Etruscans established powerful city-states and influenced neighboring peoples, including the early Romans.

Over the following centuries, different groups competed for control of the Italian peninsula. Conflicts included wars between Etruscan cities and Greek colonies, struggles against Etruscan rule, and wars among neighboring city-states. These conflicts shaped the political history of Italy for several centuries.

The City of Rome

Rome gained the most power during these conflicts. By 220 BC, Rome controlled most of the Italian peninsula south of the Po River Valley. After a major rebellion against Roman rule from 90 to 88 BC, Rome extended citizenship rights to its Italian allies.

In 49 BC, Julius Caesar also granted Roman citizenship to the inhabitants of the Po River Valley in northern Italy. By New Testament times, most of the Italian peninsula was united under Roman rule, with boundaries similar to those of mainland Italy today.

Italy in the New Testament

"Italy" appears three times in the New Testament. The apostle Paul had the opportunity to meet Priscilla and Aquila. They had come from Italy because Claudius had expelled the Jews from Rome (Acts 18:2).

Paul traveled to Rome after he appealed to Caesar (27:1, 6). The writer of the letter to the Hebrews sends greetings to his audience from "those from Italy" (Hebrews 13:24).

See also Caesars; City of Rome.

Ithai

Ithai is another spelling of Ittai, a Benjamite warrior, in 1 Chronicles 11:31.

See Ittai #2.

Ithamar

Aaron's fourth and youngest son. Ithamar served as a priest to the tribes of Israel when the people lived in the desert wilderness between Egypt and the promised land of Canaan (Exodus 6:23; Numbers 3:2–4; 26:60; 1 Chronicles 6:3; 24:2). After the death of two of his brothers, he was given the special duty of being in charge of moving of the tabernacle (Numbers 4:28, 33; 7:8). During David's reign, the descendants of Ithamar and Eleazar were organized as priests in the temple (1 Chronicles 24:3–6). Later, some of his descendants returned with Ezra from Babylon (Ezra 8:2).

Ithiel

1. Ancestor of Sallu, a Benjamite who lived in Jerusalem after the Babylonian exile (Neh 11:7).
2. One of the two persons to whom Agur spoke his proverbs (Prv 30:1, nlt mg).

Ithlah

Ithlah was a city given to the tribe of Dan after Joshua's conquest of Canaan (Joshua 19:42).

Ithmah

Ithmah was a Moabite warrior and one of David's mighty men (1 Chronicles 11:46).

Ithnan

Ithnan was a town in southern Judah (Joshua 15:23).

Ithra

The father of Amasa by Abigail, who was the sister of Zeruiah (2 Samuel 17:25). He is called Jether in 1 Kings 2:5, 32 and 1 Chronicles 2:17.

Ithran

1. Dishon's son, who was a Horite chief (Gn 36:26; 1 Chr 1:41).
2. One of Zophah's sons (1 Chr 7:37). He is probably the same as Jether mentioned in 1 Chronicles 7:38.

Ithream

The sixth son of King David. His wife Eglah gave birth to him at Hebron (2 Samuel 3:5; 1 Chronicles 3:3).

Ithrite

A family or clan that lived at Kiriath-jearim (1 Chronicles 2:53). Two of King David's mighty warriors, Ira and Gareb, were Ithrites (2 Samuel 23:38; 1 Chronicles 11:40; in the New Living Translation, they are described as being "from Jattir"). The name Ithrite may come from the place name Jattir or from a person named Jether.

Ittah-kazin

Ittah-kazin is the King James Version form of the town Eth-kazin in Joshua 19:13.

See Eth-kazin.

Ittai

1. A Philistine man from the city of Gath. He and 600 other men from Gath stayed loyal to King David when David had to flee from his son Absalom. Absalom was trying to take over the kingdom (2 Samuel 15:18–22). Ittai commanded a third of the army of David in the battle against the forces of Absalom (18:2, 5).
2. A warrior from the tribe of Benjamin who was one of the mighty men of King David (2 Samuel 23:29; spelled "Ithai" in 1 Chronicles 11:31).

Ituraea, Iturea, Itureans

Iturea was a small region near Trachonitis. Both areas were ruled by Philip, who was the brother of King Herod the Great. This happened during the time when Tiberius was the Roman emperor(Luke 3:1).

Iturea is assumed to be northeast of the Sea of Galilee, in the area of Mount Hermon. But, its location and borders are much disputed. The name almost certainly comes from Jetur, a son of Ishmael (Genesis 25:15). His descendants were among those conquered by the Israelites east of the Jordan (1 Chronicles 5:19–20).

For many years after this, we do not find any mention of the Itureans in historical records. Then, around 105 BC, the Jewish historian Josephus writes about their defeat by the Jewish ruler Aristobulus. After this defeat, many Itureans had to make a difficult choice: they could either follow Jewish religious customs and stay in their homes, or they would have to leave their homeland.

Classical writers often mention the Itureans. They sometimes call them Syrians or Arabians. They were skilled bowmen. They had the predatory tendencies of groups that could not or would not settle in one area for long. In view of this, it is not surprising that we know more about Itureans than we do about Iturea.

Strabo says they lived in a mountainous country. Dio Cassius later tells us they had a king. Their history is hard to understand due to divisions in the Roman Empire that affected them. By the end of the first century AD, many Itureans were under the provincial rule of Syria.

It is easier, then, to discuss the people than the place. Some scholars hold that Luke could not have used the noun "Iturea." This form was unknown until three centuries later. They say the adjectival form better fits the case. This prompts another question: Was this Iturean territory within Philip's tetrarchy? Could Luke have made a slip and anticipated a later regional regrouping? Josephus lists the parts of Philip's tetrarchy. He does not include Iturea.

Three facts are clear:

1. There is a certain flexibility and overlap in the descriptions of territorial borders.
2. There is not enough data for exact conclusions about Iturea.
3. The evidence is clear from other parts of Scripture that Luke is a careful and reliable writer.

Ivah

Ivah is the King James Version spelling of Ivvah.

See Ivvah.

Ivory

Opaque dentine substance, often mentioned along with precious metals and gems in the Bible and ancient Near Eastern writings. As such, ivory was used for combs, small boxes, jars, and other cosmetic articles; for figurines and amulets; for games; and for the adornment of articles of furniture, buildings, and perhaps even ships (Ez 27:6). It is frequently mentioned in Egyptian and Assyrian annals of conquest as part of the spoils of war. Some excellent examples of work with ivory can be found in the famed collection of Tutankhamen.

In the Bible ivory is spoken of as the adornment of Solomon's throne (1 Kgs 10:18; 2 Chr 9:17) and of beds in the time of Amos (Am 6:4). Both references are probably to ivory inlay. The ivory palaces of 1 Kings 22:39, Psalm 45:8, and Amos 3:15, however, may refer to forms of decoration other than inlay. Whether Ezekiel 27:6 actually implies that ships were decorated with

ivory is debatable, since that passage forms part of the whole picture of Tyre as an extravagant ship. The articles of ivory that earth's merchants can no longer sell to Babylon (Rv 18:12) include smaller objects of the kind found at various archaeological sites (Megiddo, Samaria, Nimrud).

Originally ivory was available in northern Syria, where Assyrian monarchs hunted elephants. By Solomon's time, however, it was imported (1 Kgs 10:22; 2 Chr 9:21), probably from the east (India) or south (Africa), while the ships of Tarshish may represent the seagoing capability of the ships rather than the source of the ivory. Tyre received its ivory in trade from the "coastlands" (Ez 27:15).

Ivvah

Ivvah was a city that had already fallen along with others to the Assyrians (2 Kings 18:34; 19:13; Isaiah 37:13). A representative of King Sennacherib mocked the belief of King Hezekiah that God would save Jerusalem. Ivvah was probably a city in Syria.

See also Avva.

Iye-abarim, Iyim

An Israelite camping place on the southeast border of Moab during their wilderness wanderings (Numbers 33:44). In verse 45 the town is called Iyim, which is a shortened form of Iye-abarim.

Izehar, Izeharites

The King James Version spelling of Izhar. Izar was the son of Kohath. The Izeharites were his descendants (Numbers 3:19, 27).

See Izhar #1.

Izhar

1. One of Kohath's sons from the tribe of Levi (Exodus 6:18, 21; Numbers 3:19; 16:1; 1 Chronicles 6:2, 18, 38; 23:12, 18). He was the father of the Izharite family (Numbers 3:27; 1 Chronicles 24:22; 26:23, 29). He is also called Amminadab in 1 Chronicles 6:22. One of Izhar's sons was Korah, who led the rebellion against Moses and Aaron (Numbers 16:1–11).
2. Helah's son from the tribe of Judah (1 Chronicles 4:7).

Izharite

Any descendant of Izhar from the tribe of Levi (Numbers 3:27; 1 Chronicles 24:22; 26:23, 29).

See Izhar #1.

Izliah

Izliah was Elpaal's son from the tribe of Benjamin (1 Chronicles 8:18).

Izrahiah

Izrahiah was Uzzi's son and a leader from the tribe of Issachar (1 Chronicles 7:3).

Izrahite

Designation given to Shamhuth, one of David's 12 monthly captains, meaning a man of a family or town called Izra (1 Chr 27:8). The word "Izrahite" is perhaps a corruption of "Zerahite," a descendant of Zerah of Judah (1 Chr 27:11).

Izri

Temple musician and head of the 4th of the 24 divisions of priests for service as musicians in the sanctuary (1 Chr 25:11, nlt mg). He is called Zeri in 1 Chronicles 25:3.

Izziah

Izziah was a son of Parosh. After the Israelites returned from exile, Ezra called on Izziah and other Israelite men to divorce the foreign women they had married (Ezra 10:25).